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Epistemological Disenfranchisement in the Humanitarian Sector

How Global North Metrics Marginalize Indigenous Knowledge Management

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This thesis is submitted for obtaining the Master's Degree in International Humanitarian Action. By submitting the thesis, the author certifies that the text is from his/her hand, does not include the work of someone else unless clearly indicated, and that the thesis has been produced in accordance with proper academic practices.

“Perhaps the most important task of all would be to undertake studies in contemporary alternatives to Orientalism, to ask how one can study other cultures and peoples from a libertarian, or a nonrepressive and nonmanipulative, perspective. But then one would have to rethink the whole complex problem of knowledge and power.”

— Dr. Edward W. Said (Said, 1978, p. 35)

Abstract

Through a case study of Cruz Vermelha de Timor-Leste (CVTL), the Red Cross National Society in Timor-Leste, this thesis investigates the friction between reporting metrics derived from the Global North and the Indigenous Knowledge Management (IKM) practices of the local context.

This bureaucratization of knowledge can lead to a disconnect between the lived experiences of local humanitarian workers and the information that is being reported to donors, which can ultimately impact the effectiveness of humanitarian interventions not only through reduced responsiveness but also by undermining the trust between the local humanitarian workers and the communities they serve.

Drawing on decolonial theory, the Theory of Communicative Disenfranchisement (TCD), and the Cynefin® framework, this study employs a qualitative case study methodology. Data were gathered through semi-structured interviews with CVTL staff, Australian Red Cross program officers, a United States Agency for International Development (USAID) representative, and an independent direct-funding practitioner, alongside document analysis of institutional reporting templates.

The findings reveal a structural domain misalignment at the core of humanitarian knowledge management: donor-mandated mechanisms—like logical frameworks (logframes), standardized indicators, and quarterly reports—are Clear-domain instruments imposed upon Complex and Chaotic humanitarian realities (Umbrex, 2025). Rather than capturing local knowledge, these systems suppress it. Local humanitarians are reduced to “custodians of comprehension” who complete forms to satisfy donor requirements, rather than acting as “catalysts for transformation” drawing on contextual expertise (Johar, 2025). Constant retraining sessions required to socialize staff to these tools signal the depth of the disconnect, while the administrative burden produces reporting fatigue and pressure to report outcomes that cannot be causally demonstrated.

This thesis argues that the communication chasm at CVTL reflects not an organizational anomaly but a structural incongruence rooted in colonial logics embedded in the international humanitarian system. It concludes by pointing toward complexity-informed, participatory knowledge management through the Catalyst Approach built upon Sankofaist philosophy: a relationship-based, direct funding approach that catalyzes what communities already possess rather than

supplanting it as pathways to an equitable humanitarianism rooted in indigenous knowledge management practices rather than rendering the traditions of the local humanitarians and affected communities invisible.

This thesis is dedicated to the humanitarians of the Global South who carry the brunt of the labor without the deserved recognition or reward. 2024, the year I began the NOHA program, proved to be the deadliest year yet to be a humanitarian as 861 aid workers fell victim to attacks with 383 of those killed (Humanitarian Outcomes, 2025). Not only were these humanitarians targeted while serving people in need, but also in their very own homes (Lederer, 2025). It would be erasure not to point out the fact, verified by the United Nations, that more than half of these humanitarians were murdered in Gaza at the hands of Israeli forces (Lederer, 2025). And so, to those humanitarians who do not have the privilege of flying in and out of a crisis, who are both witness and respondent to need, my thesis is in honor of you.

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List of Abbreviations

CVTL – Cruz Vermelha de Timor-Leste

DT – Disenfranchising Talk

IFRC – International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies

INGO – International Non-Governmental Organisation

KM – Knowledge Management

NGO – Non-Governmental Organisation

OECD – Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development

TCD – Theory of Communicative Disenfranchisement

UN – United Nations

USAID – United States Agency for International Development

Key Concepts

Accountability to Affected Populations: The commitment of humanitarian actors to be answerable to the people they serve, ensuring that communities have a voice in decisions affecting them and can provide feedback or lodge complaints.

Beneficiaries versus Providers: A dichotomy perpetuated by the aid industry where relations only exist between beneficiaries—receivers of resources—and providers—givers of resources; “beneficiaries” are often treated as numerical targets beholden to the priorities and conditions of “providers” (Khan *et al.*, 2022, p. 3).

Bureaucratization of Knowledge: Dr. Arturo Escobar’s term identifying the practices of institutions in professionalizing discourses about the ‘Third World’ into standardized, manageable, and technical categories; in this case study, concerns the standardization and technocratization of knowledge through formal reporting requirements, whereby complex local realities are reduced to quantifiable metrics and donor-defined “client categories” (Escobar, 1995, p. 106).

Communicative Disfranchisement: The process by which communication results in the deprivation of a person’s rights and privileges; in the humanitarian sector, this manifests as the marginalization of local workers in knowledge production (Hintz and Scharp, 2024).

Custodians of Comprehension vs. Catalysts for Transformation: A distinction by Indy Johar used to contrast workers reduced to form-filling compliance—“custodians”—with those empowered to create meaningful change—“catalysts” (Johar, 2025).

Decoloniality: The theoretical and political project of dismantling the enduring colonial logics, epistemologies, and power structures that persist beyond formal political independence; premised on the recognition that coloniality—the ongoing suppression of local knowledges, languages, and beliefs in favor of Western frameworks—remains embedded in contemporary institutions (World Decolonization Forum, 2026), including in the humanitarian sector.

Developed versus Developing Countries: Originating in the 1960s for the transfer of resources from economically rich to poor nations, this term implies that “developed” countries have reached their full potential and suggests there is only one universal way to be developed (Khan *et al.*, 2022, p. 2).

Developmentalism: The pursuit of economic growth and “the distribution of the benefits of growth” to “solve the social and economic problems of these parts of the world” classified as “Third World”/“developing nation”/Global South (Escobar, 1995, p. 5); formulated upon the “spatial power” from the division of “imaginative geographies” (Said as cited by Escobar, 1995, p. 9) where nations are labeled “First and Third World, North and South, center and periphery” (Escobar, 1995, p. 9) and these “forms of power in terms of class, gender, race, and nationality thus found their way into development theory and practice. The former do not determine the latter in a direct causal relation; rather they are the development discourse’s formative elements” (Escobar, 1995, p. 43); prioritization of “Western-style democracy as the end point of development” resulting in an “emphasis on the immediate need for order and efficiency” (Manzo, 1991, p. 4) in the intervention and management of “developing” nations’ political, economic, and cultural affairs.

Do No Harm: A foundational principle requiring that interventions—including technological ones—must not cause unintended harm to affected populations. Derived from medical ethics and formalised in humanitarian practice.

Documentary Reality: A term coined by Dr. Dorothy Smith referring to the institutional reliance on textual and documentary forms as a means of representing reality, inevitably detached from the local historical context of the experiences they purport to represent (Escobar, 1995, p. 146).

Epistemological Chauvinism: Anthropologist John Bousfield’s term for the privileging of Western ‘scientific’ knowledge as inherently superior to local, tacit, or oral knowledge (Sillitoe, Bicker and Pottier, 2002, p. 240); the ideological foundation that dismisses local expertise as anecdotal or unreliable; epistemological, as defined by Hintz and Sharpe, as “concerned with the recognition of knowledge” as well as “what counts as knowledge, and whose knowledge counts” (Hintz and Scharp, 2024, p. 91).

First World versus Third World: A post-WW2 theoretical classification embedded with racism through hierarchy, structured around the “backwardness” of the “Third World” (Khan *et al.*, 2022, p. 2) and the superiority of the “First World”; a structure treating the “individual nation-state in the Third World as the sovereign subject of development” (Manzo, 1991, p. 3).

Global North versus Global South: Emerging in the 1980s, these terms indicate divisions based on access to wealth, political power, and participation

in Western culture. Despite being geographically inaccurate—with countries like Australia falling under the classification of Global North despite existing geographically in the southern hemisphere—these terms are less problematic in comparison to other “dichotomous terminologies” used in the humanitarian and development sectors (Khan *et al.*, 2022, p. 2) but continue to perpetuate the “social production of space implicit in these terms” “bound with the production of differences, subjectivities, and social orders” (Escobar, 1995, p. 9) through “imaginative geographies” (Said as cited by Escobar, 1995, p. 9).

Goal-Coded Systems: A concept from Indy Johar describing systems whose operative purpose arrives from outside—prompted, benchmarked, and evaluated by external frames—leading to a “crisis of orientation” for those operating within them (Johar, 2026).

Humanitarian: A person engaged in efforts to “prevent and alleviate human suffering”, particularly “in times of armed conflict and other emergencies” (IFRC, 2021, p. 2).

Humanitarian Principles: The four core principles guiding humanitarian action: humanity, neutrality, impartiality, and independence. Established by the International Committee of the Red Cross and endorsed by the United Nations.

Indigenous: Historically belonging to the location in question; in the context of this thesis, “To avoid incessant definitional arguments, most anthropologists now use local knowledge (LK) and traditional knowledge (TK) as synonymous with indigenous knowledge (IK)” (Sillitoe, Bicker and Pottier, 2002, p. 27).

Local versus International: Within the aid industry, “international” is used to refer to organizations and institutions overseeing projects across the world but often based in the Global North and “local” often concerns an entity located in the Global South. While perhaps technically accurate, racial connotations may be carried when in reference to people and capacity: “‘local’ often has derogatory connotations (eg, a local working in their ‘poor’ country is juxtaposed with and considered inferior to the ‘expat’ or international expert from a rich country” (Khan *et al.*, 2022, p. 2).

Localization: A donor-promoted concept referring to the promotion of decision-making power and resources to local organizations; critiqued in this thesis as largely rhetorical, undermined by the very reporting structures imposed on local ‘partners’.

Modernization: The “adoption of the ‘right’ values, namely those held by the white minority... and, in general, those embodied in the ideal of the cultivated European” through political restructuring (Escobar, 1995, p. 43), industrialization, and transformation of socio-cultural practices; entirely analogous with “conceptual categories and Western assumptions” (Manzo, 1991, p. 3).

Myth of the Lazy Native: A concept from Dr. Syed Hussein Alatas describing the colonial ideology that portrayed native populations as lacking capacity and work ethic in order to justify exploitation and domination (Alatas, 1977) — a legacy argued to persist in current INGO paternalism toward organizations and humanitarians from the Global South.

Ordered Bias: The structural tendency of standardised reporting systems to impose rigid, linear formats onto complex and context-specific knowledge, forcing nuanced field realities into pre-defined bureaucratic categories.

Orientalism: Popularized by Dr. Edward W. Said, “a style of thought based upon an ontological and epistemological distinction made between ‘the Orient’ and (most of the time) ‘the Occident’” (Said, 1978, p. 10); European imaginations of people, space, and power.

Orientation versus Agency: A distinction drawn by Johar where agency is the capacity to pursue an end, whereas orientation is the deeper capacity to discover, revise, and be claimed by what ends are worth pursuing (Johar, 2026). Local humanitarian workers are argued to be denied orientation by donor-driven goal-coded systems.

The West versus the East/the Rest/the Orient: An ideological and hegemonic sociopolitical distinction that falsely touts human values like freedom and rationality as exclusively Western (Khan *et al.*, 2022, p. 2).

White Gaze: A term used by Shallwani and Dossa to describe how Whiteness is established as the norm in development and humanitarian evaluation, determining what counts as valid knowledge and evidence while framing Global South populations in terms of deficit (Shallwani and Dossa, 2023).

1 Introduction

CVTL is a National Society of International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC). It operates in a post-colonial context, where the legacy of Portuguese colonization as well as the subsequent invasion and genocide committed by Indonesian forces has shaped the socio-political landscape. As an auxiliary to the government, the organization's work encompasses a range of humanitarian and development activities, including disaster response, health services, and community development. CVTL currently faces a persistent communication chasm where formal reporting metrics demanded by international donors and supervisory institutions, like IFRC, differ from practices preferred by local staff and volunteers. International organizations are institutions with structures of behavior and practice that are expected to be followed by their partners, including local National Societies like CVTL.

It seems, however, that the behaviors and practices that are being demanded by the funding bodies and international partners seem not to align with the preferred practices of the local staff at CVTL. Lack of reporting is, of course, a significant concern for the donors. The reporting metrics demanded by donors are standardized across the humanitarian sector and are designed to create accountability and demonstrate effectiveness. Lack of adherence to the reporting requirements can lead to loss of funding and resources, which can have serious consequences for the organization's ability to carry out its humanitarian work and even its continued existence. The disconnect between the reporting metrics and the practices of local staff can also lead to a lack of trust and credibility with donors, which can further jeopardize funding and resources. This misalignment between demands and practices may be an anomaly to CVTL, but it is also very possible that this is an issue that is widespread across the humanitarian sector, particularly for other organizations operating in post-colonial contexts with a strong oral knowledge sharing tradition. The purpose of this thesis is to investigate whether CVTL's lack of strict adherence to the standardized reporting metrics is a localized organizational issue or if it is symptomatic of a wider structural incongruence between preferred practices of humanitarian workers from the working contexts and that of global humanitarian structures of project cycle management.

1.1 Surviving in the system

The humanitarian sector operates with a fundamental tension between local autonomy and standardization—derived from and imposed by Global North institutions—in the name of accountability. For organizations like CVTL, this tension manifests in the need to navigate the demands of international donor bodies while also maintaining their own practices and priorities that are rooted in local contexts and cultures. In order to enjoy the confidence of its donors, CVTL must demonstrate its effectiveness and accountability to them while also ensuring that its work remains relevant and responsive to the needs of the communities it serves. The adoption of reporting metrics of their donors and the Federation can be seen as a strategy for CVTL to survive and thrive within the international humanitarian system as it allows access to funding and resources that are essential for their operations.

This strategy, however, also comes with risks as it may lead to a misalignment between the preferred practices of the local staff and the practices demanded by donors. Technical upgrades, such as the implementation of digital reporting systems, are often seen as a solution to these challenges but they may not actually address the underlying issues of structural incongruence. Local practitioners may find themselves navigating a complex web of reporting requirements that do not align with their preferred ways of sharing knowledge or value the information they deem important, leading to frustration and a sense of disempowerment. The rigid, “ordered” reporting systems are demanded by the international institutions and donors that supply the funding to partner organizations in the Global South and are standardized across the humanitarian sector in an effort to professionalize the sector and create accountability. The problem is that these systems are not context-based and instead impose a one-size-fits-all approach to Knowledge Management (KM) that may not be suitable for all organizations, particularly those operating in post-colonial contexts with strong oral traditions. Local humanitarian workers may find themselves becoming “custodians of comprehension” bureaucrats tallying the numbers and filling out the forms to satisfy donor requirements — rather than “catalysts for transformation” — practitioners who are able to use their local knowledge and expertise to drive meaningful change in their communities (Johar, 2025). And so, partner organizations in the Global South, like CVTL, and their staff are left to negotiate their legitimacy within the system

while navigating the power dynamics in which they are dependent on the funding and resources provided by Global North institutions and donors.

1.2 Problem Statement

The data that is being reported and the information that is not are both important to understand the dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector. By examining the case of CVTL, this thesis seeks to shed light on the broader dynamics of knowledge production, management, and power in the humanitarian sector and to contribute to ongoing discussions about decolonizing humanitarianism and valuing diverse forms of knowledge.

1.3 Research Question

The research aims to answer the following research question:

How does the “culture of comprehension” (Katsamangos, 2025) — the bureaucratic demand for ordered, standardized reporting metrics — function as a mechanism of communicative disenfranchisement for local humanitarian workers in the Global South and in what ways do these actors navigate the tension between local knowledge management practices and the demands of international donors?

1.3.1 Study Objectives

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated digital reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an “ordered bias” that forces complex, context-specific knowledge into rigid, standardized formats?
3. How do local leaders within organizations navigate the tension between the demands of international donors and the compulsions of local knowledge management practices?

2 Methodology

This research utilizes a qualitative case study to investigate the communicative processes that shape knowledge management within CVTL, serving as an entry point to analyze the broader “documentary reality” (Smith as cited in Escobar, 1995, p. 107) created by donor institutions in the humanitarian sector. The

mixed-method research will involve a combination of participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and document analysis to gather data on the experiences and perspectives of local humanitarian workers at CVTL. Document analysis will review institutional guidelines and reports in order to understand the formal structures and expectations around knowledge management and reporting. Data analysis will be conducted using thematic analysis to identify key themes and patterns in the data. The conceptual structures for this thesis concern decolonial theory (Dorothy Smith, Arturo Escobar, Paul Sillitoe, Alan Bicker, and Johan Pottier), the TCD (Elizabeth A. Hintz and Kristina M. Sharp), and the Cynefin® framework (Dave Snowden and Alessandro Rancati) to analyze the dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector.

2.1 Ethical Considerations

This study adheres to the UCD Low Risk Study protocols, ensuring that research is conducted with respect for the dignity of participants and without causing intentional harm.

- **Informed and Voluntary Consent:** All participants are fully briefed on the study's purpose and provided written consent forms. They are informed of their right to withdraw at any time without penalty.
- **Confidentiality and Anonymity:** To encourage honesty and protect professional standing, all data is anonymized.
- **Data Sovereignty and Management:** Research is conducted in alignment with CVTL and IFRC data-sharing policies, with data stored securely according to university guidelines and accessible only to the research team.
- **Positionality and Bias:** The researcher acknowledges her positionality as an outsider to the local context and takes steps to mitigate bias through reflexivity and by prioritizing voices of local practitioners and perspectives from the Global South. The researcher also acknowledges the power dynamics inherent in the research process and strives to conduct the research in a way that is respectful to the participants. The researcher is also conscientious of the post-colonial context in Timor-Leste and her positionality as a person of Indonesian descent and a national of the United States of America—countries that bear responsibility for the genocide in Timor-Leste and its continued impact—and took care to approach the research with sensitivity. Additionally, the researcher acknowledges the bias in participant selection

due to recruitment of English-speaking participants in a context where the average Timorese person is not fluent in that language.

2.2 Utility & Limitations

The research aims not only to produce academic knowledge but to offer practical insights that can inform the practices of CVTL and the wider humanitarian community. The findings will be shared with CVTL in order to contribute to their efforts in capacity building within the organization. The research also aims to contribute to ongoing discussions about improving knowledge management practices and addressing communicative disenfranchisement in the humanitarian sector.

The limitations of this research include the potential for bias in the data collection and analysis process, as well as the limited generalizability of the findings due to the focus on a single case study, that of CVTL. Additionally, the research may be limited by the availability and willingness of participants to share their experiences and perspectives, as well as by the constraints of time and resources. The researcher will take steps to mitigate these limitations through careful data collection and analysis, as well as by being transparent about the limitations of the study in the final report.

2.3 Participant Selection

The study will include:

- Local humanitarian workers at CVTL who are involved in knowledge management and reporting processes;
- Staff from CVTL's donor organizations who interact with CVTL's reporting and knowledge management systems;
- Representatives from other donor institutions working in both Timor-Leste and elsewhere in order to provide insights into the broader context of the donor-recipient relationship and its impact on knowledge management practices.

2.4 Data Collection

Data will be collected through a combination of qualitative and quantitative methods, including:

- Semi-structured interviews with local humanitarian workers and donor representatives to explore their experiences, perspectives, and challenges related to knowledge management and reporting.
- Document analysis of CVTL’s reporting templates, guidelines, and other relevant materials to understand the formal structures and expectations around knowledge management.

2.5 Data Analysis

Data will be analyzed using thematic analysis to identify key themes and patterns related to the research questions. The analysis will be guided by the Cynefin® Framework, which provides a lens for understanding the complexity of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts, and the TCD, which offers insights into the power dynamics and marginalization of local voices in knowledge production. The findings will be interpreted with existing literature on humanitarianism, decolonial theory, and knowledge production in mind.

3 Literature Review

This literature review synthesizes existing research on the intersection of humanitarianism and development work, decolonial theory, and philosophical inquiries of knowledge itself. The review is structured around three main themes:

1. The bureaucratization of knowledge through standardized reporting mechanisms;
2. The disenfranchisement of local humanitarian workers in knowledge production and management; and
3. How these humanitarians navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences.

3.1 Strategy

The literature selection strategy for this thesis follows a qualitative approach to review current discussions regarding knowledge management. The search resulted in few examinations of specifically humanitarian contexts and instead in the related field of development. Several seminal sources were revealed to the researcher through formative conversations with classmates, interviewees, and supervisory meetings with Dr. Sulagna Maitra. The search was primarily conducted across major academic databases, including University College Dublin’s (UCD) OneSearch

tool, Google Scholar, JSTOR, ResearchGate, and Springer. The inclusion criteria prioritized peer-reviewed journal articles and foundational classics in development anthropology and post-structuralism, specifically those that examine the historical construction of the development and humanitarian sectors. The selection strategy explicitly aimed to synthesize dominant and emerging schools of thought, ranging from early post-World War modernization approaches that dismissed local knowledge as ‘primitive’ to contemporary participatory paradigms that advocate for the decolonial practices. Recommended readings and further inquiry were sparked by references within the initial readings. Primary search terminology included, but was not limited to: “information management,” “knowledge management,” “indigenous knowledge management,” “oral knowledge sharing,” “monitoring and evaluation,” “reporting,” “development,” “humanitarian,” and “decolonial”.

A primary limitation of the literature review strategy is its linguistic boundary; as the search was constrained to English-language literature, which inherently limits the perspective of the very voices the study proposes are being marginalized by Western-derived structures. The limited existing literature specifically about humanitarian work reflects the need for a focused investigation into how Global North metrics function as a mechanism of communicative disenfranchisement for practitioners in contexts like Timor-Leste.

3.2 Conceptual frameworks

3.2.1 The Cynefin® Framework

The Cynefin® framework was “designed to manage anthro-complexity, or complexity in human systems” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 57) with origins in the world of corporate business. However, its focus on times of crisis and uncertainty makes it a useful tool for understanding the challenges of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts. With its emphasis on “bounded applicability”— “that there are few, if any, context-free solution but many valid context-specific ones”— the framework is “a way of determining what method or approach” should be applied “and, critically, when you should change it” (Cynefin.io, 2023, p. 4). The Cynefin® framework identifies three types of systems:

1. Ordered systems in which cause and effect relationships are either clear or discoverable through analysis;

2. Complex systems in which the only way to understand the system is to interact;
3. Chaotic systems in which turbulence prevails and immediate stabilizing action is required.

— (Cynefin.io, 2023, p. 4)

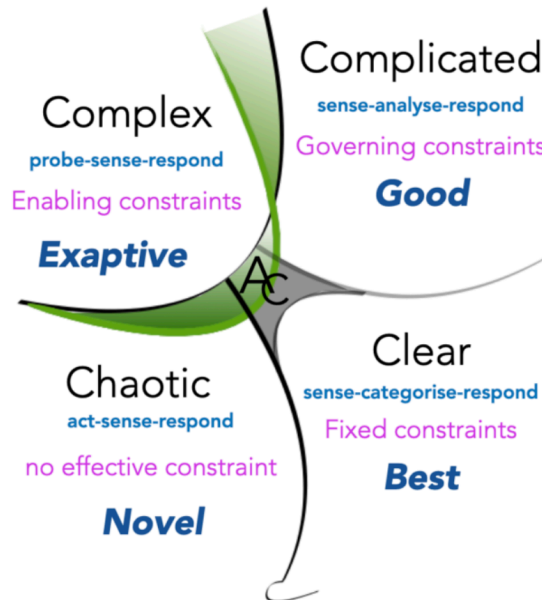


Figure 1: The Cynefin® framework
(Cynefin.io, 2023)

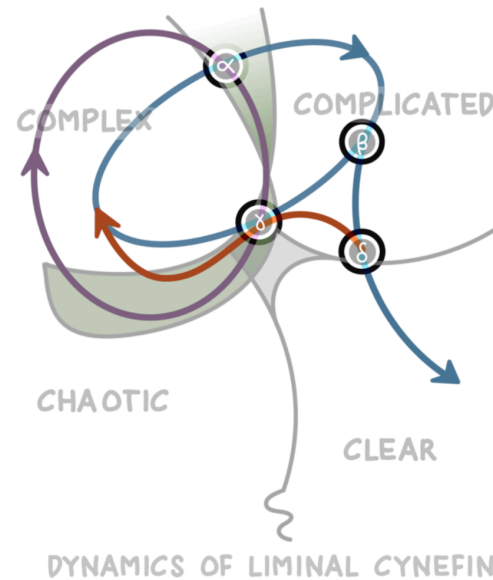


Figure 2: Movement through Cynefin®
framework (Cynefin.io, 2023)

These systems are then mapped to the five domains, decision logics that guide how to navigate and manage the system:

1. Clear: Cause and effect are self-evident; constraints are fixed; there are known, proven solutions.
 - Decision logic: Sense → Categorize → Respond
 - Guidance: apply best practice, standard operating procedures, checklists, automation.
 - Examples: routine compliance steps, password reset, standard invoice processing.
2. Complicated: Cause and effect exist but are not obvious; analysis or expert judgement is needed; constraints are governing but adjustable.
 - Decision logic: Sense → Analyze → Respond
 - Guidance: apply good practices, expert diagnosis, modeling, scenario analysis; multiple right answers.

- Examples: solution architecture selection, pricing optimization, regulatory interpretation.
3. Complex: Cause and effect are discoverable only in retrospect; patterns emerge; constraints are enabling; outcomes are uncertain and path-dependent.
 - Decision logic: Probe $\rightarrow$ Sense $\rightarrow$ Respond
 - Guidance: run safe-to-fail experiments, amplify positive patterns, dampen negatives, encourage diversity of approaches.
 - Examples: new venture models, culture change, market adoption of novel experiences.
 4. Chaotic: No perceivable relationship between cause and effect in the moment; constraints have collapsed; urgent action required to stabilize.
 - Decision logic: Act $\rightarrow$ Sense $\rightarrow$ Respond
 - Guidance: establish order fast, create or restore constraints, then transition to complex/complicated methods.
 - Examples: cyber breach unfolding, major outage, PR crisis.
 5. Disorder: You don't yet know which domain you're in; stakeholders use their preferred methods by default, often talking past each other.
 - Guidance: break the situation into parts and assign each to a likely domain; gather multiple perspectives to reduce ignorance.

— (Umbrex, 2025, p. 2)

Limitations of the framework include its focus on organizational decision-making and its potential oversimplification of complex social phenomena. However, it provides a useful lens for understanding the challenges of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts. Methodologically, because the Cynefin® framework is utilized as a “decision support framework” rather than a predictive model, the findings are intended to offer diagnostic perspective and “sense-making” rather than “context-free” or “standard solutions” (Cynefin.io, 2023). Another limitation is that as participants reflect on past reporting challenges, the data is subject to the risk of retrospective coherence, where individuals may inadvertently reframe their original state of “aporetic” confusion into a more structured and logical narrative that masks the initial complexity of the experience (Snowden and Rancati, 2021,

p. 61). The findings from the thesis research through this lens, however, must be viewed through the lens of “bounded applicability,” recognizing that the insights derived from this case study may not be universally generalizable but can offer valuable perspectives for similar contexts and contribute to broader theoretical discussions in the field of humanitarian knowledge management (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 60).

3.2.2 The Theory of Communicative Disenfranchisement

To understand the friction between Global North reporting and local field wisdom, TCD provides a useful framework. Dr. Elizabeth A. Hintz and Dr. Kristina M. Sharp developed this theory to explain how certain groups are systematically excluded from participating in communicative practices that shape public discourse and policy-making (Hintz and Scharp, 2024). In the context of humanitarian work, local humanitarians in the Global South may experience communicative disenfranchisement when their voices and perspectives are marginalized in the reporting processes that are designed to meet the expectations of Global North donors. This theory helps to illuminate the power dynamics at play in knowledge production and the ways in which local humanitarians may be excluded from shaping the narratives and policies that affect their work and the communities they serve.

Communicative disenfranchisement (CD), then, is the process by which communication results in deleterious outcomes, such as the deprivation of a person’s rights and privileges. Our focus on talk reflects our assumption that language constitutes reality, and therefore, that talk constitutes ideology... talk is construed broadly to refer to the ideological micropractices (e.g., interpersonal interactions, visual imagery, memes, and media messages) that constitute daily life and reflect informal, localized operations of power.

— (Hintz and Scharp, 2024, p. 89)

In the humanitarian sector, the “talk” of the donor—mandated procedures and practices like use of digital dashboards, log frames, and quarterly reports—all functioning as a site for the operation of ideological power. TCD shifts the analytical focus away from “bad apple” individuals and toward the “upstream” conditions that make disenfranchisement possible, specifically the hegemonic social

norms that dictate what knowledge is valued and what is dismissed as “noise” (Hintz and Scharp, 2024, p. 90). In the context of humanitarian activities, disenfranchisement is not merely the loss of a vote, but the systematic deprivation of the right to be a “knower” within one’s own professional and cultural domain.

The first proposition of TCD asserts that Hegemonic Ideologies are both reflected and constructed in Disenfranchising Talk (DT). In the case of CVTL, the primary hegemonic ideology is Western ‘scientific’ KM. This is the foundational belief that formal, codified knowledge is inherently superior to local, tacit knowledge, and that the former is absolutely necessary for accountability and effective decision-making in humanitarian work. This ideology creates a “geopolitical imagination” where Global North standards are the universal benchmark, forcing the complex social logic of Timorese communities into the ordered bureaucratic checkboxes of donor reporting requirements (Said as cited in Escobar, 1995, p. 9). DT operates through three types of functions that sustain this hegemony:

1. **Discrediting:** DT delegitimizes local knowledge and expertise by framing it as unscientific, anecdotal, or irrelevant to the goals of humanitarian work. This can lead to a devaluation of the lived experiences and insights of local humanitarians, reinforcing the notion that they are not legitimate knowers in their own right. Epistemological chauvinism is established when metrics contest the validity of local knowledge, and the truth is determined by what can be measured and reported to donors.
2. **Silencing:** DT suppresses the voices of local humanitarians by creating barriers to participation in knowledge production and decision-making processes. There is an institutionalized creation of a “documentary reality” (Dorothy Smith as cited in Escobar, 1995), a “reliance on textual and documentary forms as a means of representing and preserving a given reality. Inevitably, texts are detached from the local historical context of the reality they supposedly represent” (Escobar, 1995, p. 108). Although not confrontational in nature, silencing is a powerful mechanism of disenfranchisement because it operates through the absence of voice and representation, rather than through overt suppression. Staff are relegated into a culture of silence where their preference for verbal communication is suppressed by donor requirements for reports and documentation.
3. **Stereotyping:** DT stereotypes through the use of language and imagery that reinforces negative and reductive perceptions of local humanitarians and the

communities they serve. Systems of reporting reduce complex identities and experiences into simplified “client categories” (like “vulnerable,” “malnourished,” etc.) that fit the expectations of donors, which can perpetuate harmful stereotypes and undermine the the dignity of those served by humanitarian work. Local humanitarians, when forced to adopt the language of donors, may find themselves complicit in the very stereotyping that disenfranchises them, as they are required to frame their work and the communities they serve in ways that align with donor narratives. These humanitarians may also be stereotyped by the donors as “incompetent” or “unreliable” if they fail to meet the reporting requirements, further reinforcing the power imbalance and reflective of the archaic colonial attitude of the “Myth of the Lazy Native” (Alatas, 1977). The humanitarian sector is, in fact, built upon the “structural racism” that deems humanitarians in the Global South as lacking capacity and as inherently untrustworthy, which is used to justify the need for International Non-Governmental Organisations (International Non-Governmental Organisation (INGO)) to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production and finances (Doane, 2024, p. 58).

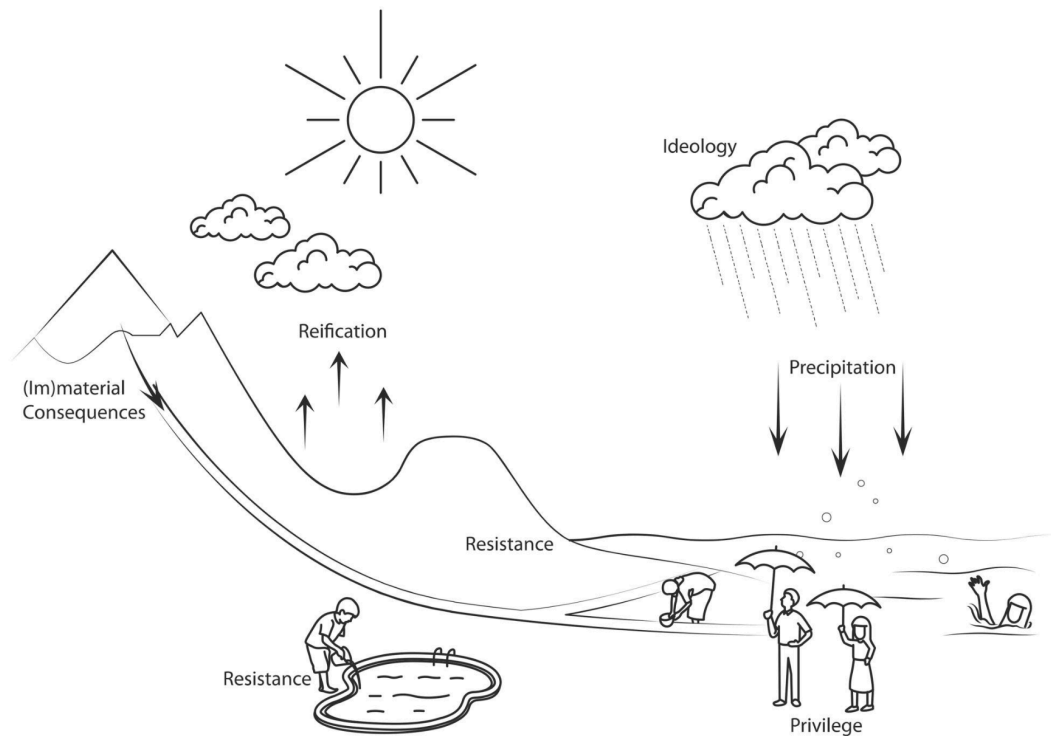


Figure 2. Visual representation of water cycle simile for operations of ideological power.

Note: We would like to thank Asmomarfaruk for the paid creation of this artwork. In this figure, the clouds represent hegemonic ideologies (taken for granted systems of meaning). Ideologies precipitate (rain down) into (im)material consequences through DT, like the ocean, the stream, and the rain. In response to these (im)material consequences of ideology, some people are complicit in perpetuating the status quo—they are overwhelmed and drown. In these cases, the water meets the ground and is reabsorbed, reifying the ideology, and continuing it as additionally viable. Others do not feel the effects of ideology due to their privilege, like holding an umbrella to avoid getting wet from the rain. Others yet resist, taking the water and using for a transformative purpose—it to fill a swimming pool. This extended simile of the water cycle illustrates the ideological conditions and ramifications of operations of ideology, as well as examples of what mechanisms individuals might employ in response.

Figure 3: Diagram of operations of ideological power (Hintz and Scharp, 2024, p. 93)

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3.3 Bureaucratization of Knowledge

In their chapter, ‘Evaluation and the White Gaze in International Development’, authors Sadaf Shallwani and Shama Dossa boldly claim:

The White gaze shapes how issues are conceptualized, understood and measured by establishing Whiteness as the norm and the White Western world as the centre of legitimate knowledge. The White gaze focuses on perceived deficits in Brown and Black people and defines success and how it can be measured. The White gaze further determines what is considered valid knowledge and valid evidence through the technocratization of the field of evaluation and its methods.

— (Shallwani and Dossa, 2023, p. 52)

This “technocratization” of knowledge is not a neutral evolution of professional standards; it is the methodological expression of a far older colonial order. In his seminal work, “Encountering Development: The Making and Unmaking of the Third World”, Dr. Arturo Escobar asks his readers not to “overlook the ways in which development operates as an arena of cultural contestation and identity construction” (Escobar, 1995, p. 15). Western sense-making has not only shaped the way that development and humanitarian aid are conceptualized, but also how they are evaluated and measured (Escobar, 1995, p. 15). The “problematization of poverty” that has been central to the development project is also central to the humanitarian system, where affected communities are framed as problems to be solved and data to be measured (Escobar, 1995, p. 17). And so, the “professionalization of development knowledge and the institutionalization of development practices” was a key aspect of ‘solving’ the problem irrespective of context and conditions (Escobar, 1995, p. 17). The humanitarian sector, which emerged alongside and in many ways from the development project, has absorbed these very systems of ‘logic’ and has inherited the legacy of Western sense-making, shaped by colonial capitalist constructions of ‘developed’ and ‘underdeveloped’, ‘First World’ and ‘Third World’, and it is from “this privileged space that economics pervaded the entire practice of development” (Escobar, 1995, p. 18). The so-called “rational techniques—planning, methods of measurement and assesment, professional knowledges, institutional practices, and the like— organizes both forms of knowledge and types of power, relating one to the other, in the construction and treatment” of humanitarian and development issues (Escobar, 1995, p. 18).

At the 2026 World Decolonization Forum session “The Problem of Knowledge Production: Decolonizing Methodologies”, Dr. Syed Farid Alatas, known for his work on the decolonization of knowledge, noted the “global neoliberal system” as being “obsessed with metrics” (World Decolonization Forum, 2026). This obsession with metrics is not just a characteristic of the neoliberal system, but a fundamental aspect of the way that knowledge is produced and valued in the humanitarian sector. At this same forum, Dr. Walter D. Mignolo, a leading scholar of decolonial theory, proclaimed, “What modernity hides is coloniality. And coloniality is the logic of domination, of appropriation, of exploitation—of diminishing your language and your knowledge and your beliefs” (World Decolonization Forum, 2026). These statements identify the power dynamics that are embedded in the

very structure of international institutions, like those that fund, manage, and shape the humanitarian sector.

Prior to the emergence of the humanitarian system, the colonial powers had already established a system of knowledge production that privileged Western ways of knowing and marginalized local knowledge in the colonies: the Mandate System of the League of Nations cemented the origins of the “technologies of management” that are still present today (Anghie, 2005, p. 191). The Mandate System was a legal framework that allowed colonial powers to administer territories that were deemed “not yet ready for self-governance” after World War I (Anghie, 2005). Although the Mandate System was ostensibly designed to prepare these territories for independence and “sought to ensure their protection” (Anghie, 2005, p. 116), it also established a system of governance that was based on the principles of Western administration and management through “not only a set of rules, but also an entire system that, among other things, would collect information, analyse that information and formulate a policy” (Anghie, 2005, p. 155). This system was established in 1919 yet the current operational structure of management and funding still stands where “the natives existed more vividly in Geneva, where all this information was gathered and processed, than they did in the mandate territories themselves. The use of these new technologies of monitoring and management created an entirely new science... ‘a science of colonial administration’” (Anghie, 2005, p. 184).

The manifestation of these structures of administration in the humanitarian sector prove to be “one of the most fundamental systemic barriers to shifting power in the system,” stated Diane Doane, author of *The INGO Problem: Power, privilege, and renewal* (Doane, 2024, p. 42). “The imposition of bureaucracy by donors and INGOs in order to protect people and whole organizations along the value chain of civil society has come to supplant the idea of meaningful engagement” (Doane, 2024, pp. 42-43). In a sector where time and effort directly correspond to life and death, or at least the ease of suffering, “the problems of bureaucracy and how it takes their time away from helping people, the ridiculous amounts of form-filling and meetings, and the expectations to keep all INGOs informed of all of their work all of the time, repeating this for every new INGO staff member that comes on board” simply undermines real-world impact (Doane, 2024, p. 18). The dynamic, minute-by-minute, changing needs of individual humanitarian situations are limited in their response due to the oversight and demands of these foreign

donors. In Doane’s assessments of Ukrainian civil society organizations (CSOs), there was widespread desire for “INGOs to be in service to their [the local CSOs] needs, to cut bureaucracy and recognize that the situation was fast-moving and that local people were much better at understanding what was needed, and how it should be delivered. Moreover, they didn’t want INGOs representing them and speaking on their behalf—they wanted their own channels to communicate and appeal to the international community and even the general public” (Doane, 2024, p. 14).

The nature of communication within monitoring and reporting as well as about humanitarian situations is largely restricted to the language of technocratization imposed by the Global North institutions that built the structure of the sector. Moses Isooba of the Uganda National NGO Forum explained to Doane,

Ultimately, all of our change in shifting power is about relationships and language is how we communicate in a relationship. We ring-fence people who get paid in development by using a coded language. We don’t want the other people to speak. We speak in acronyms, frameworks, but they’re veils, they mask the real human beings like you and me, and if we can change the language, we can build better relationships.

— (Doane, 2024, p. 72)

Western concepts, terminology, and languages are prioritized over the lived languages and sense-making of the affected communities and the local humanitarians. Rasha Sansur, a communication and resource mobilization advisor told Doane,

Development is a postcolonial construct and all of the language used was originally developed in English. So I would only ever write a funding application or an evaluation in English. If I use Arabic—even if the funder allows me to—it won’t include the phrases they need to hear to pass the funding bar. It needs to include the ‘flow’ expected by English speakers: goals, mission, outcomes, etc ... even though we might personally address things differently in our culture.

— (Doane, 2024, p. 75)

The bureaucratization of knowledge in the humanitarian sector is therefore not merely an administrative inefficiency—it is a structural mechanism through which

power is consolidated and reproduced. The frameworks, reporting templates, and formal languages that govern the sector do not simply organize information; they determine whose knowledge counts, whose voice is legible, and whose understanding of a crisis is deemed credible enough to act upon. What emerges is a system in which the people closest to humanitarian crises are the furthest from the decisions made about them, their lived expertise filtered through layers of institutional process before it ever reaches those with the authority to allocate resources or shape policy. This structural exclusion has direct consequences for the workers who navigate it daily, and it is these consequences—the disenfranchisement of local humanitarian workers from the very knowledge systems that govern their work—that the following section examines.

3.4 Disenfranchisement of Local Humanitarian Workers in Knowledge Production

This regime of order and truth is a quintessential aspect of modernity and has been deepened by economics and development. It is reflected in an objectivist and empiricist stand that dictates that the Third World and its peoples exist ‘out there,’ to be known through theories and intervened upon from the outside.

— (Escobar, 1995, p. 8)

In his article “Goal-Coded Systems and the Crisis of Orientation”, professor Indy Johar, co-founder of Dark Matter Labs, identifies the nuances that differentiate agency from orientation. Although Johar writes with a focus on Artificial Intelligence, his insights are applicable to the humanitarian sector and its systems of standardization. Furthermore, Dark Matter is a non-profit “field laboratory” analyzing “the shifts required in the underlying ‘dark matter’—monetary, economic, governance, regulatory and policy systems—to manifest transformations... towards a future of mutual thriving” and has a history of working with governments and INGOs (Future Observatory, no date). Johar argues that “goal-coded systems”—systems that are designed to achieve specific goals—can lead to a “crisis of orientation” for the users through the emphasis and “tyranny of targets” (Johar, 2026). In this case, the users being humanitarian workers in the Global South who are required to navigate these systems. The “goal-coded systems” and “their operative purpose arrives from outside. They are prompted, instructed, rewarded,

benchmarked, fine-tuned, evaluated, constrained, deployed and corrected by external frames” (Johar, 2026). The external frame, here, being the donor institutions and the wider humanitarian system that is structured around the requirements and expectations of these donors. It must be asked: What type of information is being valued and what is being left out? Who determines the value? Who “produces knowledge about the Third World” and “from what spaces”? (Chandra Mohanty as referenced in Escobar, 1995, p. 8). The supremacy of Western sense-making has long deemed indigineous knowledge (IK) “as an obstacle to development, while it has been claimed as ‘epistemological disenfranchisement’ (Odora Hoppers, 2005, p.8, 14), ‘defeated knowledge’ (Odora Hoppers, 2005, p. 14, 17), and ‘subjugated knowledge’ (Semali and Kincheloe, 1999, pp. 31-32) in the conventional development doctrine” (Sohad and Mafrolla, 2025, p. 2261).

Doane explains that one current role of INGOs is to function as intermediaries between larger donors (traditional funders like governments) and the humanitarian organizations to be funded (Doane, 2024, p. 66). More often than not, the donors and INGOs are based in the Global North—the governments of European and North American countries, large institutions and organizations like United Nations (UN), IFRC, Save the Children, etc.—while the humanitarian organizations that they fund are based in the Global South—community-based organizations, local Non-Governmental Organisation (NGO), national branches of INGOs, etc. In the name of accountabilty and transparency, the INGOs manage not only the money funneled to local organizations but the information moving upwards to donors, as well. Many critics of the sector have pointed to this structure as a key flaw of what they deem the “Humanitarian Industrial Complex” (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). Even actors within this system, like former CEO of Oxfam GB, Danny Sriskandarajah, have called out the “political economy based on the trickle-down approach” as “the heart of our business model” (Doane, 2024, p. 66).

And so with billions of dollars flowing through this system, INGOs have a vested interest in maintaining their cut of the pie justified through narratives around trust, accountability, and transparency. There is an assumed mistrust of local organizations and their inability to manage funds and information, which is used to justify the need for INGOs to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production and finances (Doane, 2024, p. 10). And so based on this narrative, there must be oversight. Who is assumed to be trustworthy? The INGOs based in the Global North. What results is paternalism fueled by a legacy

of colonial power dynamics (Chandra Mohanty as referenced in Escobar, 1995, p. 9). The Mandate System of the league of nations was designed to place the former colonies under the “tutelage” of colonial powers (Anghie, 2005, p. 116).

Utilizing the Cynefin framework to “map the landscape of experiences”, one identifies the Global North as the “holder of the solution” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) in the current structure of the humanitarian system with the Global South positioned as a problem to be solved. The “predominant strategic function” of this colonial discourse “is the creation of a space for a ‘subject peoples’ through the production of knowledge in terms of which surveillance is exercised... in order to justify conquest and to establish systems of administration and instruction” (Chandra Mohanty as referenced in Escobar, 1995, p. 9). Dr. Syed Farid Alatas explains that although current discourse labels the world today as “post-colonial,” what is more accurate is the term “neo-colonial” (World Decolonization Forum, 2026). “This was said by Sukarno in 1955 at the Bandung Conference—that colonialism has not gone away. Neo-colonialism means colonialism without being politically ruled by Europeans, but in terms of culture, military, political, and intellectual dimensions, we are still very much controlled” (World Decolonization Forum, 2026). Dr. Mignolo added, “now there are no more settlers to speak of, except in Israel—the only remaining case of settler colonialism in the traditional sense. In the rest of the world, coloniality operates without settler colonialism: through military bases, financial control, control of the dollar, control of mass media” (World Decolonization Forum, 2026).

In the humanitarian sector, the Global North continues to exert power and control over the Global South primarily through the management of information and finances as well as the imposition of Western norms, values, and practices. There is still “a form of governmentality that in marking out a ‘subject nation’”—in this case the communities and local humanitarians of the Global South— in which the Global North “appropriates, directs and dominates its various spheres of activity” (Homi Bhaba as cited in Escobar, 1995, p. 9). Shallwani and Dossa synthesize this very dynamic as it manifests in development work, the sister of the humanitarian sector:

Evaluation in global development centers on the White subject as the doer, the Savior and the neutral expert. It establishes Whiteness as the norm, identifies deficits and problems in the lives of Black and Brown

people and demonstrates how interventions designed and funded by the Global North are necessary and effective—thereby reinforcing the feel-good element of the White Saviorism. Furthermore, the White gaze contorts the purposes and ethics of evaluation. While couched in the discourse of ‘accountability’ and ‘evidence-based’ decision making, evaluation implicitly serves as a tool for White surveillance and intervention on Brown and Black lives in the Global South.

— (Shallwani and Dossa, 2023) [p. 43]

The lack of trust granted to local humanitarians and the underestimation of their capacity are the lasting effects of colonial capitalism, played out in what Dr. Syed Hussein Alatas deemed “The Myth of the Lazy Native”:

In its historical empirical manifestation the colonial ideology utilized the idea of the lazy native to justify compulsion and unjust practices in the mobilization of labour in the colonies. It portrayed a negative image of the natives and their society to justify and rationalize European conquest and domination of the area. It distorted elements of social and human reality to ensure a comfortable construction of the ideology.

— (Alatas, 1977, p. 2)

One would be hard-pressed to deny the eerily similar characteristics of colonial capitalism found in the humanitarian system today, particularly through:

- (a) predominant control of and access to capital by an alien economic power,
- (b) the control of the colony by a government run by members of the alien power, acting on its behalf,
- (c) the highest level of business, trade and industry, held by the alien dominating the community...
- (f) the organization of production around semi-free labour,
- (g) the absence of guilds or trade unions as a counterweight to exploitation,
- (h) the non-involvement of large sections of the population...
- (i) the presence of a set of antitheses in the colonizes society described by the term dualism.

— (Alatas, 1977, p. 2)

White Saviorism, while often dismissed as a problem of representation, is actually a symptom of the deeper structural issues of the humanitarian system, which are rooted in racial, colonial power dynamics. The legacy of this structure continues to influence the production of knowledge in the way that information is managed, evaluated, and reported. “Local people may have some participation in evaluation processes,” writes Doane, “but it is ultimately the assessment of a northern-based (usually) white person from the outside who determines a project’s success. Those on the ground are not, in any way, holding international actors to account” (Doane, 2024, p. 52).

3.5 Navigating the Tension Between Standardized Reporting and Lived Experiences

The “western-derived”, ill defined notion of ‘capacity’—a trait humanitarians from the Global South are assumed to lack—lays the foundation for paternalism through intervention and oversight by Global North institutions (Doane, 2024, p. 50). According to Doane, “most risk management and due diligence systems” of these institutions are concerned with capacity (Doane, 2024, p. 50).

Unfortunately, the assessment of who has ‘capacity’ has been weaponized and used as means to justify the slow relinquishment of power by INGOs and their hollow promises of localization. We require more individuals actively engaged in community work and fewer confined to their desks, endlessly reporting to donors.

— Michael Vincent Mercado, Voice and Insights Lab Team Manager at the Center for Disaster Preparedness Foundation (Doane, 2024, p. 50)

Donors hype vague concepts of ‘empowerment’ and ‘localization,’ but the extent of autonomy granted to local ‘partner’ organizations and their staff is limited by the standardized reporting mechanisms. Looking back to Johar’s thoughts on “goal-coded systems”, he argues that orientation is often overlooked:

Orientation is deeper than agency. Orientation is the formation of concern. It is the emergence of direction from within a life, a body, a history, a field of relations, a condition of vulnerability, a horizon of death and continuity. Orientation is not merely the capacity to pursue an end.

It is the capacity to discover, revise and be claimed by what ends are worth pursuing.

— (Johar, 2026)

Without genuine orientation, individuals become “custodians of comprehension” rather than “catalysts for transformation” (Johar, 2025). In the humanitarian sector, this can manifest in the way that local humanitarian workers must prioritize satisfying donor requirements. These humanitarians have to spend their time filling out forms and writing reports that are designed to meet the expectations of donors rather than interacting with the communities they come from and serve.

In a study of the digitalization of indigenous knowledge, the concept of “Sankofaism” proved foundational to this thesis:

Sankofaism is a philosophical paradigm that focuses on promoting African and indigenous ways of knowledge and skill development (Dei 2012). The African concept of Sankofa emphasises building bridges between the past and present to offer a formidable future. It provides a renaissance launch pad for the preservation of a treasured positive past, which seeks to provide the foundations that promote methodologies that are consistent with realities in Africa (Eshun 2011). It is a pivotal theme in Afrocentric education, philosophy and cultural milieus as it presents platforms for confronting mischaracterisations of African creative and pedagogical spaces (Bastos 2009).

— (Mdhluli *et al.*, 2021, p. 3)

Localization from a Sankofaist approach is not a box to be checked and instead is its very orientation. A truly Sankofaist design would not produce this tension at all as locals would be the creators and evaluators, answerable only to themselves and oriented within their own traditions of sense-making. It is within this tension between the externally imposed orientation of donor-driven reporting systems and the suppressed orientation of local knowledge traditions that this thesis situates its empirical investigation into the communicative disenfranchisement of humanitarian workers in Timor-Leste.

4 Discussion and Analysis

But with such standardization of metrics, one must ask whose stories are being told and how? What knowledge is being valued and what is being left out? What type of information can be measured?

4.1 Findings in Relation to the Study Objectives

The findings of this study will be analyzed in relation to the three main themes through the study objectives:

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an ordered bias?
3. How do local humanitarian workers navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences?

4.1.1 Perceptions of Mandated Reporting Tools

Even amongst the Western organizations, there is an acknowledgement of the foreign origins of the reporting tools. In an interview with two staff members for international programs at Australian Red Cross (ARC), they admitted that “at the end of the day, these are Western ideas around monitoring and evaluation that are being imposed. These are donor-led. The National Societies, in this context with CVTL, would not be going down this path unless it was for us saying this is a donor requirement” (“Interview with Australian Red Cross Staff Members,” 2026). The local humanitarians recognize the need to comply with these requirements, not just to secure funding but also to ensure the work is in line with the strategic priorities of the organization and to maintain accountability to the communities served, explained a CVTL staff member (“Interview with CVTL Staff Member Coordinator,” 2026). They explained that tools like log frames do serve a day-to-day purpose for their staff and volunteers as responsibilities and tasks are then easy to track and manage (“Interview with CVTL Staff Member Coordinator,” 2026). Socialization—that is, the process of learning and internalizing the norms and practices—is a key part of how these tools are adopted and used by local humanitarians. Every interview conducted noted that these reporting tools cannot be implemented without the behavioral training, socializing the staff to the preferred practices of the Global North donors and INGOs. From observation, repeated training sessions are held in an effort to socialize the staff to these tools, and there is a clear emphasis on the importance of compliance with donor requirements in

these trainings. The need for constant and repetitive training sessions to socialize the staff to these tools is a clear indication of the disconnect between the preferred practices of local humanitarians and the standardized reporting mechanisms that are being imposed on them. “I always prefer to communicate verbally first to our supervisor and then last we make it in the email so when we communicate we ensure that he knows what happened,” explained a CVTL officer (“Interview with CVTL Officer,” 2026). One CVTL staff member noted that field officers often complain of being “too busy” to complete reporting requirements (“Interview with CVTL Staff Member Coordinator,” 2026) and the USAID interviewee validated the “intense” “administrative burdens” (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026).

4.1.2 Ordered Bias in Reporting Mechanisms

As it stands, not only is the information that is being reported to donors disconnected from the lived experiences of local humanitarian workers, but these workers are also disenfranchised in the knowledge production process. The standardized reporting mechanisms that are designed to satisfy donor requirements often do not take into account the local knowledge and expertise of local humanitarian workers, and instead prioritize the information that is deemed valuable by donors. Through the Cynefin® framework’s “sense-making” process, one sees how the reporting systems in the humanitarian sector are an attempt to impose order on complex and chaotic systems (Cynefin.io, 2023, p. 4). Donor-mandated mechanisms—log frames, standardized indicators, quarterly reports—are fundamentally Clear and Complicated domain tools: they presuppose that cause and effect are knowable, that best practices apply, and that outcomes can be categorized in advance (Umbrex, 2025, p. 2). Yet humanitarian response itself operates in the Complex and Chaotic domains, where outcomes are uncertain, cause and effect are ‘discoverable only in retrospect’, and the appropriate logic is to probe and adapt rather than to sense, categorize, and execute (Umbrex, 2025, p. 2). This domain misalignment is a structural one: imposing a Clear-domain decision logic upon a Complex or Chaotic situation does not simplify that complexity—it suppresses it, filtering out the contextual, relational, and emergent knowledge that defines effective response. Perhaps most telling is the Disorder domain, in which “stakeholders use their preferred methods by default, often talking past each other” (Umbrex, 2025, p. 2): this captures precisely the disconnect between Global North donors

applying ordered-system logic and local humanitarians navigating the complex realities of the field. The communication chasm between CVTL and the donors may be understood, in part, as a domain misalignment—a mismatch not of effort or capacity, but of the decision logic being applied to the system.

“Our brain is not like a computer in such an ordered way. Things come in different ways and so sometimes the mixed information makes it difficult to write a good report,” explained one CVTL staff member (“Interview with CVTL Staff Member Manager,” 2026). The persistence of the demands for ordered mechanisms of reporting has resulted in “fatigue” among the local humanitarian workers, explained the USAID interviewee. They noted that donors often operate in multiple countries, and so:

They want to have a unified system for reporting so that they can take all this information and aggregate it together. This was classic USAID or World Bank or many of the other agencies. They come up with these systems that, number one, don’t necessarily match what people are kind of accustomed to and number two, which is maybe a related issue, is that the donors don’t coordinate their systems with one another. So each donor has its own way of doing things and its own. So the partners can sometimes get a little bit fatigued by this because, you know, USAID wants one kind of reporting and the Germans want another kind of reporting and the EU wants another kind of reporting and it gets a little exasperating, to be honest, from their side.

— (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026)

The “administrative burden” (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026) can often eclipse the purpose of the project and, as noted earlier by Johar, the “goal-coded system” results in a “crisis of orientation” (Johar, 2026). Humanitarians put their administrative efforts into tracking easily identifiable elements, like indicators, while information that is less quantifiable or dependent on a longer time-frame is overlooked (“Interview with Australian Red Cross Staff Members,” 2026; “Interview with CVTL Staff Member Coordinator,” 2026; “Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026; “Interview with CVTL Staff Member Manager,” 2026). Tracking the more simple and quantitative data (like number of meeting attendees, amount of fliers distributed, etc.) is also a “really easy for them to prove that they’re using the funds in an accountable way through the indicators”,

noted the USAID interviewee (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026). But in terms of project effectiveness, there is often an imbalance in the amount of effort put into tracking outputs and indicators versus outcomes. “Trying to capture whether a community is stronger or an organisation is stronger is the outcome level where the complexity comes in. I think it’s the sort of outcome level more evaluative questions that are more likely to come in friction”, explained one of the ARC interviewees (“Interview with Australian Red Cross Staff Members,” 2026). This places managerial and supervisory national staff in a particularly precarious position: they must simultaneously satisfy the reporting demands of donors while compensating for the incomplete work of their lower-level officers, absorbing the additional administrative steps themselves rather than delegating them down the chain. While officers and volunteers may excel at tracking quantitative information like indicators, outputs, and activities on the mandated forms, one managerial staff member at CVTL expressed frustration at the limited reports they receive that identify results and outcomes (“Interview with CVTL Staff Member Manager,” 2026).

“Monitoring these kinds of things and reading between the lines for quarterly and annual reports was a constant exercise to try and figure out well like what is actually going on,” noted the USAID interviewee who often relied on “a little insider information. But that’s not systematic, right? That’s all just very kind of anecdotal, and if you’re lucky, you get it, and more often, most of the time, you don’t” (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026). The intangible nature of success leaves so much room for interpretation that in order to justify the funds spent, report writing frequently stretches the correlative relationship between a project and outcomes (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026).

CVTL is feeling that as well because they’re under pressure to report on things and one of the problems with putting that kind of pressure—and it’s not that the pressure is just completely wrong, I mean there’s a reason for it—but sometimes just to satisfy the funder yeah you want to say something that sounds sort of outcome-ish. They may be on shaky ground trying to report on that so that’s another aspect of it.

And then the last piece of this, of course, is the the so-called attribution piece: How on earth do I know that this particular funding contributed to this outcome? And how do I measure that? That was

always a very, very tricky issue as well. There was a lot of reporting that I did on my side where we, you know, I'm not saying we're sort of dishonest, but I felt like we fudged a little bit and said, 'well, we're going to take some credit for some larger, higher level goal.' But I couldn't really give you a sort of nice causal, logical path and say because we gave 2 million dollars for such and such and we did the following things that is exactly why this thing changed. There could have been all sorts of other factors that were involved, and probably there were. So that also makes outcome reporting tricky as well. But there is pressure to report on outcomes because that's what everybody wants to see.

— (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026)

Yet this pressure and structure is not an absolute necessity. The founder of a non-profit that provides direct funding to local humanitarian organizations across more than 70 countries described a deliberately different philosophy: “We don't want to know how the watch was invented... sophistication means simplicity not complexity” (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). Rather than layering on the kind of multi-indicator frameworks and attribution demands described above, this funder builds accountability through sustained relationships with local organizations, treating trust as the mechanism of oversight rather than paperwork. The contrast is instructive: the reporting burden that exhausts local humanitarians and incentivizes strategic ambiguity is not an inevitable feature of responsible funding—it is a design choice based on neocolonial power dynamics. Where donor systems are engineered to aggregate and compare across countries, this model accepts that local complexity cannot and should not be flattened into a unified template. The dysfunction traced throughout this section—the fatigue, the fudging, the administrative eclipse of the actual work—follows from a particular institutional logic, and the existence of funders who explicitly reject that logic suggests the problem is structural rather than inherent to accountability itself.

4.1.3 Navigating the Tension

This structure demands its participants to adopt the behaviors and practices of the Global North, justified through the language of ‘professionalization’, ‘accountability,’ and ‘efficiency’. Through the framework of TCD, this language constitutes Disenfranchising Talk (DT): the rhetorical packaging of Western organizational

norms as universal professional standards discredits local practices through implication rather than confrontation (Hintz and Scharp, 2024) —not by directly challenging the legitimacy of Timorese ways of working, but by presuming a single, self-evident model of what it means to work “professionally”. Even the ARC staff noted that the “professional persona” expected of the local humanitarians at Red Cross National Societies “is very much informed by models and organizational structures that mirror Western structures” (“Interview with Australian Red Cross Staff Members,” 2026). The silencing function of DT becomes most legible in this moment of enforcement. When questioned about potential resistance to the socialization efforts that ‘educate’ officers and volunteers on institutionally-mandated monitoring and reporting practices, a CVTL staff member noted plainly, “If you don’t want to use this system it means you are not a fit. Maybe it’s not your place to work here” (“Interview with CVTL Staff Member Manager,” 2026). Resistance is not engaged with and instead rendered disqualifying: the system is not defended on its merits but positioned as a precondition for belonging in the sector. The message is not that the system is right, but that questioning it is professionally fatal.

What results is not genuine adoption of donor-mandated practices but a learned performance of compliance, a navigation strategy in which local humanitarians internalize the vocabulary and visible behaviors of accountability while managing a persistent gap between what they report and what they know. Forced into “goal-coded systems” whose “operative purpose arrives from outside—prompted, instructed, rewarded, benchmarked, fine-tuned, evaluated, constrained, deployed and corrected by external frames” (Johar, 2026). Local humanitarians retain agency only in the narrow sense in that they can execute the required tasks but they are denied what Johar calls “orientation,” the capacity to discover and be claimed by what ends are worth pursuing (Johar, 2026). They become, in Johar’s terms, “custodians of comprehension rather than catalysts for transformation” (Johar, 2025). Those who develop fluency in translating community realities into donor-legible language are rewarded and retained while those who cannot or will not make this translation are pushed out of the institutionalized sector and the funding and resources available within it. Navigating the system requires a demanding performance over time, it gradually colonizes the worker’s own relationship to their indigenous knowledge management practices.

This dynamic lays bare what the language of humanitarian coordination routinely obscures: the relationship between donor and local organization is not one of equals. The term *partner*—ubiquitous in donor agreements, program documents, and institutional rhetoric—implies a horizontal relationship defined by mutual respect and shared decision-making authority. Within TCD, the word functions as a hegemonic ideological construct: sustaining the fiction of collaboration while simultaneously concealing its coercive conditions, and shifting any critique of the arrangement from a structural question of power to an interpersonal failure on the part of the local organization. In practice, however, the power asymmetry is profound: donors control funding, set reporting requirements, define success metrics, and reserve the right to exit. “The nice way to say it would be ‘partner’ but from a legal standpoint it’s a grantee or it’s a contractor,” explained the USAID interviewee (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026). Local organizations, by contrast, absorb the administrative burden, adapt their internal systems to external demands, and ultimately depend on continued donor approval for their operational survival. Calling this a partnership does not make it one.

The fiction of partnership is not merely semantic—it actively forecloses accountability by framing donor-imposed conditions as collaborative agreements, and by shifting any critique of the arrangement from a structural question of power to an interpersonal failure of the local organization to engage constructively. This language functions ideologically, normalizing donor authority while rendering local dependency invisible; yet the term persists precisely because it is useful to those who hold power within the relationship.

Even “localization” efforts are built upon and perpetuate this power imbalance. Localizing can take the form of international organizations from the Global North setting up country or regional offices (Doane, 2024, p. 25). “Not only did this form of localizing potentially displace funding away from local organizations—there is some anecdotal evidence showing that rather than growing the space” (Doane, 2024, p. 93) the presence of these representatives from the Global North “effectively cannibalizing the sector, rather than adding value” (Doane, 2024, p. 26).

Localization can also refer to the intention of involving local actors into project design, implementation, and evaluation. While this approach may sound more egalitarian, the USAID officer interviewed admitted that in actuality INGOs often treat it as “a hand-holding exercise” to assist a local organization to “build up

their capacity” once they were deemed to reach a suitable level of competency (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026).

We used to joke in USAID that our job was to work ourselves out of a job, right. You would hope, but not under this situation only the most truly altruistic person wants to actually work themselves out of the job—especially if you’ve got kids, you’ve got a mortgage, and all these things. So you have a certain self-interest in seeing *these* kinds of localization efforts continue. Because if you say, ‘oh, well, they can do it on their own now,’ well now what do *we* do? But if you say, ‘well, they made some real improvements in this area but they’ve got serious gaps here so what we really need to do is refocus the money on this area where we feel they’re still super weak,’ there’s your justification!

— (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026)

This is not a system failing at the margins; it is a system working exactly as designed by the Global North. To quote the incomparable Dr. Edward Said, “In a quite constant way, Orientalism depends for its strategy on this flexible positional superiority, which puts the Westerner in a whole series of possible relationships with the Orient without ever losing him the relative upper hand” (Said, 1978, p. 15) The question becomes not how to reform individual actors but how to build approaches that do not require their altruism. The following section draws on emergent practice and theoretical interventions to consider what such a response might look like.

4.2 Implications for Practice

The Cynefin® framework emphasizes the importance of context in decision-making and problem-solving. An element of contextual awareness is acknowledging the “need to establish meaningful processes of stakeholder engagement beyond user research to make sense of local experiences and build whole ecosystems from the bottom-up” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37). Furthermore, problem-solving through such “complexity-informed” approaches will find “the answers emerge from the same group who is researching and acting in the landscape” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37). Rather than the affected communities and their local humanitarian workers becoming data and subjects to be known and measured (Escobar, 1995), they are active participants in the process of making sense of their

lived experiences and the way this information is used to inform decision-making and action. This is a shift from the traditional top-down approach to humanitarian aid, where decisions are made by external actors based on standardized data and metrics, to a more participatory and inclusive approach that values local knowledge and experiences. The current approach of “prescription and direction” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) from funding agencies and INGOs, who rely on standardized reporting tools and metrics, continue to place external actors as “holder of the solution” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) with local humanitarians as instruments to be used and communities as problems to be solved, data to be measured, and subjects to be known.

There are already—and have always been—beacons of change working quietly in the sector, overshadowed by the dominant paradigms and giants of this “Humanitarian Industrial Complex” (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). In contrast to the rigorous reporting requirements of traditional donors and INGOs, there are emerging models of funding and support that prioritize local knowledge, expertise, and power. This founder called out the “limousine liberals”—the industry giants that siphon off funds intended to support work in affected communities (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). Instead, money is allocated to the overhead costs of these Global North institutions and their staff that parachute into communities for short-term projects. This founder’s accusations are not unwarranted, in fact, Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) has “finally acknowledged” that “giving through INGOs”—or “fund-emediaries”, as some have dubbed them— “actually costs more” than giving directly to community-based organizations (Doane, 2024, p. 61). The overspending is precisely due to the “inflated international overhead and salary costs” that the founder interviewed called out (Doane, 2024, p. 61). In fact, direct funding to local intermediaries and organizations “can deliver programming that is 32% more cost efficient than [through] international intermediaries” (Doane, 2024, p. 61). So why is money still being funneled through these intermediaries? The legacy of colonial power dynamics and the narratives of mistrust that justify the need for INGOs to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production continue to perpetuate this system, even in the face of evidence that it is not the most effective way to support affected communities. Doane argues that it is the responsibility of these institutions holding privilege to recognize their perpetuation of colonial, racial dynamics and to take active steps to make space for the local humanitarians and

the communities served (Doane, 2024). While “milestone agreements”, what the USAID interviewee explained as funding arrangements where local organization “just kind of goes out and does it work” and is only required to report back to the donor once they have reached a specific, pre-defined point in the project, already exist in practice but are far from common. Although the administrative burden is reduced, these arrangements are only granted by large institutional donors to the local organizations that are “well known” and in which there is already “a certain amount of faith and trust” (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026) suggesting a history of success navigating the Humanitarian Industrial Complex. The founder interviewed basis their funding tructure similarly but with greater emphasis on refusing to “reinvent the wheel” or “push down” reporting requirements onto local partners (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). Instead, they rely on relationship-building to vet local practitioners who then provide receipts and “progress reports on a volunteer basis” rather than as a mandated, rigid exercise (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). This approach is intentional: by resisting the imposition of Western bureaucratic norms, the founder seeks to preserve what they described as the “real richness” of local culture and ways of knowing (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). By identifying existing organizations to offer direct funding, the foundation aims to “enhance what they [the local organization] are doing and become more like a catalyst” by supporting the ways in which they are already working (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). “We do not want to ever change their value system, their culture, because that’s where the real richness come from. We believe in absolute pluralism. We don’t believe that a garden should only have one kind of flowers. We don’t go through bureaucracy and make it difficult for people.” (“Interview with Funder,” 2026).

This Catalyst Approach is an operational and relational approach for reform founded on Sankofaism (Mdhluli *et al.*, 2021), what Escobar envisions as grassroots “return to culture” movements (Escobar, 1995, p. 14): rather than treating local knowledge and practices as deficits to be corrected through standardized frameworks, this approach positions them as the generative foundation—catalyzing what communities already possess and their indigenous realities rather than supplanting it with diagnoses and prescription from Global North evaluators. Where mainstream donors extract local organizations into the logic of the Humanitarian Industrial Complex through bureaucratic burdens like reporting requirements and conditionality, this model is an approach for project design to be built from the

ground up by the actual humanitarians in and from the contexts in question, the ones the direct funder recognizes as having “skin in the game” (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). The Catalyst Approach provides the structural space required for Sankofaism to flourish, without imposing any one cultural norm, in promotion of enfranchisement of local humanitarian practitioners. By removing the the relentless donor demand for standardized, ‘ordered’ comprehension, the Catalyst Approach allows local practitioners the freedom to step away from their desks and engage in the “renaissance launch pad” of Sankofaism, building a future that is authentically grounded in their community’s “treasured past” that continues to inform their current behaviors and practices (Mdhluli *et al.*, 2021, p. 3).

	Sankofaism	Catalyst Approach
Primary Focus	Epistemological: how knowledge is defined	Operational: how aid is funded and managed
Mechanism	Historical continuity of indigenous practices	Relationship-building (instead of bureaucracy)
Stakeholders	Community	Community (including local humanitarians); donors are purely investors
Problem Addressed	Epistemological disenfranchisement and loss of cultural identity	Bureaucratic burden and ordered bias

Table 1: Sankofaist foundation of the Catalyst Approach

5 Conclusions

This thesis aims to explore these questions through a case study of CVTL with a focus on understanding how reporting metrics are shaping knowledge management practices and if this may be leading to epistemological disenfranchisement. In the humanitarian sector information carries the weight of life-saving decisions as it determines resource allocation. The way information is produced, shared, and valued can have profound implications for the effectiveness and equity of humanitarian work. This clear misalignment between demands and practices could be leading to epistemological disenfranchisement, where the value of IKM is marginalized in favor of metrics that are more easily quantifiable and aligned with

Global North institutions’ efforts to standardize and “professionalize” (Escobar, 1995) the humanitarian sector.

The dysfunction documented in this study of CVTL is not incidental but structural: it follows from an institutional logic in which the instruments of accountability are simultaneously instruments of epistemic control. The domain misalignment identified through the Cynefin® framework is not merely a technical incompatibility between reporting tools and complex humanitarian realities—it is a political one. This arrangement is one prioritizing a “culture of comprehension” (Katsamangos, 2025) —the bureaucratic demand that knowledge be rendered in ordered, standardized, and quantifiable forms before it is recognized as legitimate—a demand that systematically excludes the emergent, relational, and contextually embedded knowledge that defines effective local humanitarian practice. Through the lens of TCD, what presents itself as professionalization is revealed as a silencing mechanism that does not simply exclude indigenous knowledge management practices from the formal record but systematically trains local humanitarians to devalue and discard them. The persistence of this arrangement, even as donors and INGO staff openly acknowledge its dysfunction, points to the colonial power dynamics that continue to undergird the sector—dynamics that are obscured by the language of partnership, localization, and capacity-building. Yet the existence of alternatives—the direct funders, the Catalyst Approach, the practitioners who refuse the performance of compliance—demonstrates that this logic is neither inevitable nor irreversible. The central contribution of this thesis is therefore not merely diagnostic: it is to insist that the question of what knowledge counts, who is authorized to produce it, and in whose image accountability is designed is not a technical problem amenable to better monitoring and evaluative frameworks, but a political one that requires a fundamental redistribution of epistemic and financial power in the humanitarian sector.

5.1 Recommendations

The evidence presented in this thesis points toward several concrete shifts that the humanitarian sector must undertake if epistemological disenfranchisement is to be meaningfully addressed.

First, donors and INGOs must fundamentally reconceive their accountability frameworks in light of the domain misalignment identified through the Cynefin® lens. Reporting tools designed for Clear and Complicated domains—log frames,

standardized indicators, quarterly output trackers—are structurally incapable of capturing the emergent, relational knowledge that defines effective humanitarian response in Complex and Chaotic contexts. Accountability should instead be re-designed around “complexity-informed” processes that allow “the answers emerge from the same group who is researching and acting in the landscape” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37), centering local humanitarians and affected communities as cproducers of knowledge rather than as data sources to be extracted and translated into donor-legible templates.

A second, inseparable recommendation is to redirect funding flows away from INGO intermediaries and toward direct, trust-based relationships with community-based organizations. OECD’s acknowledgement that routing funds through INGOs “actually costs more” (Doane, 2024, p. 61)—with direct funding delivering programming that is up to 32% more cost-efficient—removes the economic justification for the current intermediary model. What remains is the colonial logic of mistrust: the assumption that local organizations cannot be trusted to steward resources without the oversight of a Global North institution. Dismantling this assumption requires institutional donors to invest in relationship-building as the primary mechanism of accountability, not as a substitute for oversight but as a more honest and effective form of it. Milestone agreements, in which local organizations work autonomously and report only at agreed-upon project junctures, represent a step in this direction, but must be extended beyond the organizations that are already “well known” (“Interview with USAID Staff Member,” 2026) to those that have historically been excluded from the sector’s inner networks precisely because they refused to perform compliance.

Third, the structural reforms above must create genuine space for what Sankofaism offers: a return to and reinvestment in indigenous knowledge management practices that the current system has systematically devalued. Where the Catalyst Approach succeeds, it does so not by introducing new frameworks but by removing the demand for standardized, ordered comprehension that forces local humanitarians away from the “real richness” of their cultural ways of knowing (“Interview with Funder,” 2026). Following Sankofaism’s logic of building a future authentically grounded in community practice (Mdhluli *et al.*, 2021, p. 3), donors should actively resist the impulse to fill the space vacated by reporting requirements with alternative Western frameworks. The goal is not replacement but withdrawal: creating the structural conditions for local knowledge systems to re-emerge on

their own terms, as the foundation from which community-rooted humanitarian action is designed, implemented, and evaluated.

This is not a promotion for the absence of knowledge, it is a call for the creation of space for more than one type of knowledge:

Thus, the supremacy of Western knowledge is not explained by a privileged closeness to the truth, but rather by a mix of historic-geographical circumstances linked up with the geopolitics of power (Escobar, 1995). In this sense, IK can be termed as the body of historically constituted knowledge that was instrumental in the long-term adaptation of human groups to the biophysical environment. Conclusively, development projects should be designed including the IK of people to whom the projects are addressed (Tumwebaze et al., 2024), rather than rely on the universal acceptability and superiority of SK and “developmentalism” (Escobar, 1995), thus redefining and diversely informing the concept of development per se and its aims (Sillitoe and Marzano, 2009), calling for the need of an integration of IK and SK (Bohensky and Maru, 2011), where IK is not a subjugated knowledge, but it collaborates with SK to achieve development (Wang, 2012).

— (Sohad and Mafrolla, 2025, p. 2261)

Collectively, these three recommendations find their ethical grounding in two principles that the humanitarian sector formally endorses but structurally undermines. The first is “do no harm”: understood not only in its conventional material sense but epistemically—the recognition that imposing knowledge frameworks which displace and systematically devalue local ways of knowing constitutes a form of institutional harm in its own right. The second is accountability to affected populations: the commitment that humanitarian actors are answerable, first and foremost, to the communities they serve rather than to the donors who fund them. The current reporting apparatus inverts this relationship entirely, directing the flow of accountability upward toward institutional donors while the people most affected by resource allocation decisions remain peripheral to—and largely absent from—the knowledge systems designed in their name. The reforms proposed here do not simply improve operational efficiency; they begin to restore accountability to its proper direction and to operationalize “do no harm” in a domain the sector has long exempted from its own ethical scrutiny.

5.2 Limitations and Scope

This study makes no claim to generalizability in the statistical sense as these findings are grounded in a single-organization case study of CVTL. While the structural dynamics identified—domain misalignment, communicative disenfranchisement, and the colonial underpinnings of INGO intermediary models—are consistent with broader critical scholarship on the humanitarian and development sectors, direct extrapolation to other National Societies or community-based organizations requires caution. Different contexts will carry different configurations of power, different colonial inheritances, and different degrees of institutional dependency; what holds for CVTL may manifest differently elsewhere.

The qualitative and interpretivist design of this study, while appropriate to the research questions, introduces its own constraints. The interview sample, though purposively constructed to include perspectives across the donor-INGO-local-organization spectrum, is necessarily limited in scale. The absence of voices from community members directly served by CVTL—those most distant from the reporting apparatus and most affected by resource allocation decisions—represents a gap that future work must address. Their exclusion was a practical and ethical constraint of the study's scope, not a theoretical one; the epistemological argument advanced here is, in fact, strengthened by centering those voices.

The theoretical frameworks applied—the Cynefin® framework, TCD, and Sankofaism—are interpretive lenses rather than neutral instruments. Each foregrounds particular dynamics and, by doing so, necessarily places others out of frame. Applying Cynefin® to analyze domain misalignment, for instance, reveals the structural incompatibility between reporting tools and complex humanitarian realities but does not speak to the full range of organizational factors that shape how that incompatibility is experienced. TCD illuminates the silencing functions of professionalization language but does not exhaust the analysis of power within donor-implementer relationships. Readers should understand these frameworks as productive entry points into the problem rather than exhaustive explanations of it.

Finally, this research reflects a moment in time. The humanitarian sector is not static: the period in which this study was conducted has seen intensifying debate about localization, growing donor acknowledgement of intermediary inefficiency, and the emergence of funding models—such as the Catalyst Approach examined here—that explicitly contest dominant logics. The findings reported here may

already be in partial motion; the sector's power dynamics are contested, and future configurations may look different. This is not a limitation so much as a reminder that the critique offered here is addressed to a moving target, and that structural change—however slow—is possible.

5.3 Potentials for Further Research and Application in the Humanitarian Sector

The limitations above are simultaneously invitations. Each gap in this study points toward a productive site for future research.

The most immediate extension is comparative: applying the same analytical framework—domain misalignment, communicative disenfranchisement, and the Catalyst Approach as an alternative—across multiple National Societies or community-based organizations in different geographic and post-colonial contexts. Such comparative work would allow researchers to distinguish between dynamics that are structural features of the Global North humanitarian architecture and those that are specific to the Timorese context. It would also surface the full range of ways in which local organizations navigate, resist, and adapt to reporting demands—a diversity of strategies that a single case study cannot capture.

A longitudinal dimension is equally pressing. This study documents a moment of tension and nascent change; what is missing is evidence of trajectory. Do organizations that adopt direct-funding models over time demonstrate measurably different outcomes in staff retention, community trust, or program effectiveness? Do practitioners who work within the Catalyst Approach eventually reconstitute indigenous knowledge management practices, or do the residual habits of compliance persist? These are empirical questions that require time and sustained engagement to answer.

There is also significant analytical work to be done at the policy level. The Cynefin® framework, adapted here as a diagnostic tool for analyzing reporting system design, could be operationalized into a practical instrument for donor policy reform—a framework for auditing existing accountability mechanisms against the domain logic they presuppose and the domains in which they are deployed. Such an instrument would give institutional donors and INGOs a concrete, non-ideological entry point for identifying where their systems are structurally misaligned with the realities their partners navigate, potentially opening space for

dialogue that does not require participants to first accept the full weight of the colonial critique.

Sankofaism and the Catalyst Approach, while theoretically generative, remain underdeveloped as operational frameworks. What does Sankofaism look like in practice across different cultural contexts in which indigenous knowledge management takes forms distinct from those documented here? What institutional conditions are required for the Catalyst Approach to scale without itself being captured by the logic it seeks to displace? These questions call for collaborative research between practitioners and scholars—research that is itself structured by the principles it advocates, produced from within communities rather than about them.

Finally, this study identifies a clear gap in the TCD literature: while the theory was developed in organizational contexts in the Global North, its application here to the donor-implementer relationship in international humanitarian work reveals its purchase on structural power dynamics that extend well beyond its original scope. Extending TCD to other asymmetric aid relationships—between multilateral institutions and national governments, between international research institutions and the communities they study—would both test the framework’s limits and sharpen its capacity to reveal how communicative norms function as instruments of epistemic control across scales.

The broader contribution this thesis makes to the humanitarian sector is not a single recommendation but a reframing: the question of what counts as knowledge, who is authorized to produce it, and in whose image accountability is designed is not a technical problem that better tools can solve. It is a political problem that requires political solutions—solutions that redistribute epistemic and financial power rather than optimize its current allocation. The research directions outlined above are not neutral inquiries; they are, at their best, acts of intellectual solidarity with the practitioners whose knowledge this study sought to make legible.

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A Interview Guide

A.1 Core Theme Questions

Interview questions were designed with the three study objectives in mind:

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated digital reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an “ordered bias” that forces complex, context-specific knowledge into rigid, standardized formats?
3. How do local leaders within organizations navigate the tension between the demands of international donors and the compulsions of local knowledge management practices?

The semi-structured style of interviews resulted in conversations that were often classified after-the-fact into one of these three study objectives.

A.1.1 Concerning Perception of Mandated Reporting Tools

- Why do you think that donors want data?
- Does tracking the information interrupt your time with the people in the community and building relationships with them?
- Do you find it easy to report data that isn’t numbers?

- Do you find that your outcomes are easy to track or is it much easier to track the indicators?
- If you didn't have to use the log frame, do you think that your people and yourself would be tracking the project in the same way?
- How do you explain to the community the success of a project?

A.1.2 Concerning Ordered Bias

- Do you ever feel like you have to emphasize particular information because it might be more interesting to the donors?
- Would you argue that the imposition donors place on partner organizations to report in a bureaucratic way is also an imposition of culture?
- How would you respond to critiques that the demand by donors for rigorous reporting removes staff from actionable work and turns them into bureaucrats?
- Have you ever wanted to record information but there was no place on a form?
- Do you feel any pressure to provide numbers?
- Who do you think owns the information collected? CVTL? The community? The donors?

A.1.3 Concerning the Tension Between Reporting and Lived Experience

- Would you prefer to talk to your supervisors about the information you saw in the community instead of recording the information on paper or through KoboToolbox?
- Do you think that these local staff, in order to be successful, essentially have to become more westernized?
- What is your theory on why field staff are not doing the reporting?
- How do you hold them accountable if the relationship isn't an honest one (e.g., based on shows of deference)?
- Do you think it's because it was never their own idea [the reporting system] that it's not something they're going to adopt?

B Logical Framework Matrix

“The Logical Framework or Log-Framework was established as a means to introduce greater structure into project design. It is useful due to its iterative nature and the inclusion of various project cycle stages: implementation, monitoring, evaluation and overall alignment of project steps up unto the end product.

It's four-by-four matrix structure covers the core parts of the original framework. Here, we describe it as a five-times-six matrix structure. With the help of this structure, one can relate each of the activities undertaken to specific indicators in order to make visible what has been achieved and what remains to be established:

- SMART results and objectives guiding the project downwards and upwards from aim to operationalisation and vice versa;
- SMART indicators giving measurable answers to when, where and who;
- a baseline indicating the state of the indicator before the project start and against which to measure progress;
- a target indicating the state the indicator aims for;
- means of verification providing information about sources for utilised indicators; and
- important assumptions necessary to be in place at every stage for achieving the end product. They reflect changes in the external environment, influencing project performance beyond the control of project management. Besides assumptions, a fifth row for preconditions may be relevant to some projects, stating what is necessary to be in place in order for the project to initially start.

The structure of the Log-Framework is as follows: lower columns feed into the next higher one, while each column (sustainability objectives, end product, milestones, outputs, inputs) is supported by indicators, baselines, targets, verification means and important assumptions. In formulating this matrix, an iterative approach of testing and refining or revising stages is adequate throughout project planning and implementation. Only in- and outputs, also referred to as activities and results, are under the direct control of a project and comprise the building blocks for the work plan. Inputs comprise the tangible and intangible means with which outputs in the form of products or services are developed.⁴⁹ Milestones, end product and sustainability objectives lie outside the project boundary, so that activities and results work towards them and have a combined impact on them. This Log-Framework provides the basis for work plans.“ (Heintze and Thielbörger, 2018, p. 444)

Narrative Summary	Performance Indicators	M&E / Supervision	Important Assumptions
CAS Goal: Higher objective to which this project, along with others, will contribute.	Indicators (increasingly standardized) to measure program performance.	The program evaluation system.	(Goal to Super Goal) Risk regarding strategic impact.
D.O. The impact of this project. The change in beneficiary behavior, systems or institutional performance because of the combined output and key assumptions.	Impact Measures that describe the accomplishment of the PDO The value, benefit and return on investment.	People, events, processes, sources of data for organizing the project evaluation system.	(D.O. to CAS Goal) Risk regarding program level impact.
Outputs The project intervention. vWhat the project can be held accountable for producing.	Indicators that measure the value added of implementation of the components.	People, events, processes, sources of data – supervision and monitoring system for project implementation.	(Output to D.O.) Risk regarding design effectiveness.
Components The main component clusters that must be undertaken in order to accomplish the Outputs.	Input / Resources Budget by component. Monetary, physical, & human resources required to produce the Outputs.	People, events, processes, sources of data and monitoring system for project design.	(Component to Output) Risk regarding implementation and efficiency.

Figure 4: Template for a Logical Framework Matrix (World Bank, 2005, p. 16)

C Relevant sections from the **IFRC Principles and Rules for Red Cross and Red Crescent Humanitarian Assistance**

C.1 Principles

These Principles and Rules recognize the importance of **strengthening organizational, coordination and delivery capacities of National Societies**, to respond to the increasing number and complexity of disasters and the growing number of vulnerable people. **They call for greater collective learning, adaptation, innovation and leadership to ensure that the Movement achieves greater humanitarian impact.**

These Principles and Rules encompass preparedness for response, disaster relief and early recovery activities. They complement commitments to disaster risk reduction and seek to encourage National Societies to link relief, recovery and development. **They establish a coordinated and agreed approach**

to quality and accountability, and recognize partnerships with public authorities, humanitarian actors and other organizations external to the Movement.

These Principles and Rules are adopted within the statutory framework of the Movement. These Principles and Rules are adopted by member National Societies and their International Federation and will be presented to the International Conference of the Red Cross and Red Crescent in 2015. They shall be a part of the future Movement-wide **coordination and cooperation framework**.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 3)

Our assistance adheres to the Movement's Fundamental Principles: it is based on humanity, respects impartiality, neutrality, and independence, is in conformity with unity and universality and builds upon voluntary service.

1. We, the National Societies and the International Federation, consider that all persons affected by disasters are entitled to receive assistance, consistent with their needs and priorities.
2. **We respect the dignity of all people affected by disasters, including their meaningful involvement in decisions that affect their lives and livelihoods.**
3. **We commit to protect people affected by disasters, particularly those made vulnerable by any form of discrimination.**
4. We have the duty to bring humanitarian assistance to those in need. We partner with states, which have the primary responsibility to meet the needs of disaster-affected people in their countries.
5. We advocate on behalf of people at risk and affected by disasters for increased action to address their vulnerabilities and unmet humanitarian needs.
6. We increase and expand our assistance through mobilising our network. We commit that all international assistance provided by a National Society or the International Federation is with the consent of the National Society of the disaster-affected country.
7. **We are each other's primary and preferred partners. We pursue operational partnerships with external actors – consistent with our Fundamental Principles – to further increase operational reach, scale and effectiveness.**

8. We ensure that our assistance is well coordinated among ourselves and with relevant external actors.
9. **We ensure that our assistance is appropriate, efficient, effective, and accountable, and we support the transition from relief to recovery for disaster affected people.**
10. **We provide international assistance that builds upon local capacities and complements local response mechanisms, contributing to preparedness for possible future disasters and strengthening long-term resilience.**

(IFRC, 2021, p. 4)

C.2 Rules between and among National Societies and the International Federation

C.2.1 National Societies receiving international humanitarian assistance

C.2.1.1 Preparedness:

- 1.2 Preparedness measures may include but should not be limited to:
 - a. **Risk, vulnerability, capacity and market assessments;**
 - b. **Development of contingency plans and processes with stakeholders;**
 - c. Monitoring and using regional and national hazard forecasts for early warning and early action;
 - d. Conducting and concluding pre-disaster meetings and agreements;
 - e. Convening and participating in simulation exercises with relevant partners;
 - f. **Building necessary volunteer, staff and organizational capacity to provide timely disaster response; and**
 - g. **Building necessary organizational capacity to receive and account for international assistance.**
- 1.3 National Societies shall strive to continuously strengthen their auxiliary role to the public authorities in the humanitarian field, including through **establishing clear roles and mandates as set out in applicable legislation, policies and plans.**
- 1.4. National Societies shall encourage and support the relevant public authorities to **review and develop legislation, policies and plans for disaster management, including by using the [Guidelines for the](#)**

domestic facilitation and regulation of international disaster relief and initial recovery assistance (IDRL Guidelines) to strengthen their overall legal, policy or institutional frameworks to both regulate and facilitate disaster assistance.

- 1.5. Key outcomes of preparedness measures, including relevant agreements and cooperation arrangements concluded, should be shared with the International Federation.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 5)

C.2.1.2 Requests for assistance

- 1.6 National Societies may ask the International Federation to provide or facilitate international assistance prior to an imminent disaster on the basis of reliable scientific forecasts and early warning information.
- 1.7 National Societies shall inform the International Federation of any sudden or slow-onset disaster for which international assistance may be required and provide, as soon as possible, relevant information including:
 - a. The nature of the disaster, estimated extent of human and physical impact, and the likely future development of the situation;
 - b. Any preliminary assessment of needs and the immediate priorities for assistance;
 - c. Actions taken thus far by the National Society and its partners;
 - d. Actions taken by public authorities or other actors; and
 - e. All requests for international humanitarian assistance.
- 1.9 When international assistance is sought to respond to the humanitarian needs of people affected by disaster, the National Society should request from the International Federation the following support as necessary:
 - a. Immediate financial support from the International Federation's Disaster Relief Emergency Fund;
 - b. The launch of an Emergency Appeal on behalf of the National Society;
 - c. Request the deployment of global/regional disaster response tools;
 - d. Request technical, managerial or additional coordination support.

- 1.10 The National Society may also request bilateral assistance from National Societies **in accordance with established frameworks for coordination agreed with the International Federation.**
- 1.11 When international humanitarian assistance is not requested but such assistance is accepted by the National Society, the National Society shall **establish a framework to receive, coordinate, account and report for such assistance with the support of the International Federation as needed.**

(IFRC, 2021, p. 6)

C.2.1.3 Coordinated and principled response

- 1.12 The National Society, together with the International Federation and its partners shall define the strategic objectives for Red Cross Red Crescent international humanitarian assistance.
- 1.13 The National Society shall work with the International Federation to ensure that international Red Cross Red Crescent assistance is effectively coordinated between and among Movement and non-Movement actors at both strategic and technical levels.
- 1.15 The National Society shall ensure systems, procedures and appropriate processes are in place to be able to account for and report regularly on the funds and in-kind resources received and expenditures it incurs.
- 1.16 The National Society shall share information through established Movement coordination systems on the following:
 - a. Results of on-going needs and risks assessments;
 - b. Progress against operational plans and capacity strengthening;
 - c. Priorities of the government and activities of other actors in country;
 - d. Any operational or institutional concerns or risks, including plans for using unspent funds; and
 - e. Emerging gaps in resources and operational capacities.
- 1.20 In disasters affecting the border areas of neighbouring countries the concerned National Societies shall ensure **continuous exchange of information between themselves either directly or through the International Federation and, where relevant, collaborate** to improve access

to disaster-affected people or improve the quality of humanitarian assistance provided.

- 1.21 If a National Society receives goods it has neither solicited, nor agreed to receive or which are of unsuitable quality, it is free to use or dispose of them at its discretion. **All costs incurred by the National Society in receiving or disposing of any unsolicited goods shall be borne by the sending National Society. (ref 2.4.)**

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 7-8)

C.3 National Societies providing international assistance

C.3.1 Preparedness

- 2.1 **In order to ensure efficient and coordinated international assistance, National Societies shall work together with the International Federation to, where applicable:**
 - a. **Participate in coordinated assessment and contingency planning processes** and simulation exercises;
 - b. Support National Societies in their engagement with public authorities, as requested;
 - c. **Conclude pre-disaster agreements on the provision of humanitarian assistance and cooperation, and share these with the Movement partners through the International Federation;**
 - d. Ensure the pre-positioning of relevant relief stocks and surge **capacities**;
 - e. **Support the coordinated development of the global, regional and national disaster response mechanisms and surge capacity tools;**
 - f. Regularly monitor hazard information to guide planning and to alert partners on potential upcoming humanitarian assistance needs; and
 - g. **Ensure adequate training and preparation for response staff and volunteers.**

(IFRC, 2021, p. 8)

C.3.2 Responding to requests

- 2.3 All assistance must respond to the humanitarian needs and priorities as identified by the requesting National Society **with the support of**

the International Federation, and follow applicable coordination mechanisms.

- 2.4 **The sending National Society is responsible for all costs incurred** by the National Society in receiving or disposing of any goods which it has not solicited, agreed to receive, or has judged to be of unsuitable quality. (ref 1.21)
- 2.5 National Societies shall **prioritise Red Cross Red Crescent channels** when providing international humanitarian assistance. **Non-Movement channels** of assistance (including donations to non-Movement partners) **shall only be used when agreed** with the National Society in the affected country. **National Societies will inform the International Federation.**
- 2.6 When global/regional disaster **response mechanisms** and **surge capacity tools** are deployed, initial assistance should be channelled through them and must be **coordinated with these mechanisms and tools to ensure operational efficiency and effectiveness.**

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 8-9)

C.3.3 Coordinated and principled response

- 2.7 National Societies providing agreed international assistance **shall inform the receiving National Society and the International Federation in advance** of all cash and in-kind goods and personnel that they intend to send. **They shall also provide all relevant supporting documents** to the receiving National Society or International Federation in advance for timely clearance from public authorities.
- 2.8 When global or regional surge capacity tools are requested and subsequently deployed, the responding National Societies and the International Federation shall **provide a detailed description of the tools to be deployed, in-country support required and the initial deployment timeframe, to the receiving National Society.**
- 2.9 Where National Societies have agreed operational partnerships with external actors they shall coordinate with the National Society in the disaster affected country and other relevant Movement components to **ensure common standards and coherent approaches to humanitarian assistance.**

- 2.10 If National Societies wish to transfer relief stocks which are reserved for an International Federation operation, they may do so **only with the prior agreement of the International Federation.**
- 2.11 National Societies providing assistance shall seek to allocate adequate resources to improve disaster preparedness and reduce disaster risks when responding to disasters.
- 2.12. National Societies shall **share timely information on their assistance with the receiving National Society and the International Federation.**

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 9-10)

C.4 The International Federation

C.4.1 Preparedness

- 3.1 **The International Federation shall support National Societies** in their efforts to reduce the vulnerabilities of disaster-prone people and improve their resilience to disasters.
- 3.2 **The International Federation shall promote and support the strengthening of National Societies' capacities to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of disaster response.**
- 3.3 The International Federation, supported by the National Societies, shall **maintain and develop global and regional multilateral disaster response mechanisms and surge capacity tools that are relevant to changing operating environments and compatible with national response mechanisms.**

Global and regional response mechanisms and surge tools include but are not limited to: Disaster Management Information System (DMIS), Disaster Relief Emergency Fund (DREF), Early Recovery Surge Team (FERST), Emergency Appeal (EA), Emergency Response Units (ERUs), Field Assessment and Coordination Teams (FACT), Heads of Operations (HEOps), Household Economic Security (HES) team, Regional Disaster Response Teams / Regional Intervention Teams (RDRT/RIT), Restoring Family Links (RFL) pool, Shelter Technical Team (STT), and Shelter Coordination Team (SCT).

- 3.4 The International Federation shall **monitor hazard information and disseminate relevant warnings to National Societies and promote and share information** on key disaster preparedness efforts, initiatives and good practices at national, regional and global levels.
- 3.5 The International Federation shall ensure that **globally consistent policies, rules, standards, tools and procedures relevant to disaster response are developed, disseminated and updated, as well as promoting their use in local contexts.**

(IFRC, 2021, p. 10)

C.4.2 Reponding to requests

- 3.6 When the International Federation receives a request for **international assistance from a National Society, it may:**
 - a. Provide support from the Disaster Relief Emergency Fund;
 - b. Launch an Emergency Appeal covering the Federation-wide disaster response;
 - c. Deploy global and regional disaster response **mechanisms and surge capacity tools;**
 - d. **Provide support for the preparation of emergency plans of action;**
 - e. **Provide or facilitate the provision of other services requested** by the National Society;
 - f. Perform its role as set out in any pre-disaster **agreement;** and/or
 - g. **Propose other international assistance mechanisms as may be relevant to the specific context.**
- 3.7 Where the National Society does not intend to request international humanitarian assistance, **the International Federation may, in consultation with the affected National Society, send representatives to the disaster-affected country to gather information and assist the National Society in its response.**
- 3.8 **Where the International Federation considers that a National Society has not requested international assistance adequate to the scale and impact of the disaster,** the International Federation shall make its concerns known to the National Society and propose appropriate action to be taken in order to respond to the humanitarian needs of the affected people.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 11)

C.4.3 Coordinated and principled response

- 3.9 The International Federation shall **organize, coordinate and direct** international Red Cross Red Crescent humanitarian assistance.
- 3.10 The International Federation is **responsible for ensuring that coordination** of international Red Cross Red Crescent assistance occurs at the **strategic and operational levels and ensures that a consolidated operational plan is developed.**
- 3.11 The International Federation shall **encourage and facilitate operational consortia and other forms of alliances among National Societies which support coordinated and efficient action.**
- 3.12 The International Federation shall support and promote regional responses as appropriate through **regional programming approaches, tools and funding mechanisms.**
- 3.13 **As the official representative of the National Societies in the international field,** the International Federation shall ensure the representation and coordination with international and regional humanitarian organizations. The International Federation **may temporarily delegate international representation roles to National Societies.**
- 3.14 The International Federation shall **provide the direction and management over any deployed global and regional surge capacity tools** agreed with the receiving National Society. The International Federation **may assume any other direct operational role** as agreed with the National Society in the disaster-affected country.
- 3.15 The International Federation shall seek to ensure that global humanitarian diplomacy approaches to disaster response are **strategic and coordinated** with other Movement components in the interest of addressing the key humanitarian concerns of the disaster-affected people.
- 3.16 In the context of international humanitarian assistance, **the International Federation shall work with the National Society in the affected country to promote and protect its organizational objectives and interests.**
- 3.17 The International Federation will **disseminate relevant operational information,** including plans of action, appeal coverage, the status of

expenditures and commitments, activities undertaken, unmet needs, and **potential operational and reputational risks.**

- 3.18 The International Federation, in agreement with the concerned National Societies **shall ensure that realtime evaluations are commissioned for major response operations and reviews and evaluations are carried out for other operations, on behalf of all operational partners, and that their findings, recommendations and agreed action points are disseminated and followed up.**
- 3.20 The International Federation shall seek to **ensure that adequate resources are mobilised** to improve disaster preparedness and reduce disaster risks when responding to disasters.

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 11-12)

C.4.4 Relief to recovery

- 4.1 National Societies **shall ensure that disaster-affected communities are involved in planning and decision making regarding relief and recovery programming.**
- 4.2 National Societies and the International Federation shall **develop responsible transition and handover strategies based on the needs and priorities of disaster-affected people, available funding and local capacities.**

To ensure **appropriate and timely** relief and recovery programming National Societies should:

- a. Assess recovery needs and commence planning within the immediate response;
- b. **Engage in participatory planning with affected communities and other relevant actors;** and
- c. Ensure that a multi-sectorial relief and recovery strategy is developed and implemented fostering **community driven recovery**, and addressing crosscutting issues, such as gender, violence prevention and environmental sustainability.

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 12-13)

C.5 Quality and accountability

C.5.1 Standards

- 5.1 National Societies and the International Federation undertake to work in **compliance** with the [Code of Conduct for the International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement and Non-Governmental Organizations in Disaster Relief](#) and with the [Code for Good Partnership of the International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement](#) .
- 5.2 National Societies and the International Federation shall work to continuously improve the **efficiency and quality** of international humanitarian assistance by ensuring the implementation of the [Humanitarian Charter and Minimum Standards in Humanitarian Response \(the Sphere Project\)](#) and other **relevant standards** in all humanitarian assistance operations.
- 5.3 **All assistance should seek to minimise any potentially harmful social and economic impacts of assistance (“do no harm”)**, as well as take account of international environmental standards.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 13)

C.5.2 Beneficiary engagement

- 5.4 **National Societies and the International Federation consider themselves as accountable to disaster-affected people and shall involve them in needs assessment and decision-making to ensure that assistance is appropriate and meets their needs and priorities.**
- 5.5 National Societies and the International Federation shall work to **put in place transparent communication, feedback and complaints mechanisms** which invite disaster affected people to share concerns regarding the assistance provided. The National Societies and the International Federation shall ensure appropriate follow up on feedback.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 13)

C.5.3 Planning, monitoring, evaluation, and reporting

- 5.6 National Societies and the International Federation shall **put in place mechanisms for timely and effective needs assessment, planning, monitoring, evaluation and reporting**. This may include **building the capacity** of staff and volunteers to undertake:
 - a. Rapid and detailed needs, damage and loss **assessment**;

- b. **Assessment** of the capacities within the communities to respond and provide assistance;
 - c. **Assessment** of the impact of the disaster on local markets and social capital;
 - d. Primary and secondary data **analysis**, and consideration of cross-cutting issues relevant to the context;
 - e. **Strategic and operational planning**; and
 - f. **Monitoring, evaluation and reporting activities**.
- 5.7 National Societies and the International Federation shall utilize **participatory approaches to planning, monitoring, evaluation and learning**. They shall ensure that good practices and evaluation **reports are disseminated and agreed recommendations are acted upon**.
- 5.8 In all disaster response operations where international Red Cross Red Crescent assistance is provided, National Societies and the International Federation shall **cooperate to ensure Federation-wide planning, monitoring and reporting** in order to provide a comprehensive picture of the entirety of the assistance provided.“)

(IFRC, 2021, p. 14)

C.5.4 Staff and volunteer management

- 5.9 National Societies and the International Federation shall seek to employ staff and volunteers with appropriate technical qualifications and relevant skills and **ensure access to relevant training and support for the tasks assigned to them**. They shall be required to commit to staff codes of conduct ensuring appropriate standards of behaviour.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 14)

C.5.5 Resource management

- 5.12 National Societies and the International Federation shall **mobilise resources for humanitarian assistance according to the scale of need and ensure that they are appropriate to, and used for, their intended purposes**. Resources shall only be mobilised in the territory of another National Society with the prior agreement of that National Society.
- 5.13 National Societies shall maintain sound resource management practices according to their national laws. **The National Societies and the International Federation shall apply internationally approved ac-**

counting practices that are consistent and transparent to ensure efficient use of all resources.

- 5.14 National Societies shall cooperate with the International Federation to use and develop joint operational support systems and shared service platforms for effective use of resources and better service delivery.
- 5.15 National Societies and the International Federation shall strive to negotiate donor agreements which are consistent with Federation standards where applicable and which have realistic outcomes and deliverables for the operational context and capacities.
- 5.16 When changes must be made to operational plans or donor agreements to better respond to the changing needs of the disaster-affected people, the National Societies or the International Federation shall communicate these changes to concerned donors and other stakeholders in a timely manner.
- 5.17 National Societies and the International Federation shall meet all donor requirements to which they have agreed, including timely production of accurate and coherent financial and narrative reporting.
- 5.18 Relief funds or goods that are surplus to relief needs shall be used for recovery activities related to the same operation or for disaster preparedness and risk reduction activities as agreed with the donors.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 15)

C.5.6 Risk management and audit

- 5.19 Funds received for an operation, whether directly from donors or from the International Federation, shall be subject to external audits. These audits shall be commissioned by the relevant donors, the International Federation or the National Societies receiving funds. The relevant parts of such annual audit reports and written reports on actions taken in response to audit recommendations shall be shared with the International Federation and National Societies providing assistance.
- 5.20 National Societies and the International Federation shall systematically identify, evaluate and mitigate any potential operational and reputational

risks related to the receipt or provision of international humanitarian assistance.

- **5.21 National Societies and the International Federation shall put in place systems and procedures, including adequate control and oversight mechanisms, codes of conduct, policies and training, to prevent acts of fraud or corruption.**
- **5.22 When fraud or corruption is suspected, necessary action shall be promptly taken. Allegations will be investigated and follow-up action taken as necessary. National Societies and the International Federation shall facilitate and cooperate as needed in each other's investigations and ensure timely and appropriate information sharing and disclosure to relevant stakeholders**

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 15-16)

C.6 Relations with external actors

C.6.1 Humanitarian agencies and other organisations

- **7.1 National Societies and the International Federation shall engage in a coordinated manner with humanitarian agencies and other actors which seek to strengthen overall coordination, quality and efficiency of humanitarian assistance.**
- **7.2 When considering establishing an operational partnership with an external actor, the National Society should ensure that such partnerships shall not weaken the response capacity of the National Society or the image and reputation of any component of the Movement operating in the country. Guidance may be sought from the International Federation, prior to entering into such partnerships.**
- **7.3 National Societies may appeal for funding through United Nations' funding mechanisms for activities in their own countries only provided that they can adhere to the Fundamental Principles and rules and regulations of the Movement and the International Federation.**
- **7.4 The International Federation may annex its Emergency Appeals to United Nations' funding mechanisms to inform the wider humanitarian community of the International Federation's humanitarian activities with a focus on collaboration and coordination.**

(IFRC, 2021, p. 18)

C.6.2 Private sector

- 7.5 National Societies and the International Federation **shall enter into partnerships with private sector actors that** have respect for the Movement's humanitarian values, **have a positive image, and a track record of good ethical behaviour. Due diligence must be performed** on all private sector partnerships when the emblems of the Movement and their designations are used.
- 7.6 National Societies and the International Federation **shall not accept donations from sources which risk the image or reputation of any component of the Movement.**
- 7.7 Volunteers from **corporate partners** may only be used in international humanitarian assistance if they are **trained for the tasks assigned, adequately insured, and placed under the full management and control** of the sending National Society or National Society of the affected country. The National Society of the affected country must approve the deployment and **the International Federation must be informed.**

(IFRC, 2021, pp. 18-19)

C.6.3 Final provisions

- 8.2 These Principles and Rules are **binding** on the National Societies and the International Federation. Any violations or other **reputational and operational risks shall be reported to the appropriate governance mechanism.**
- 8.3 National Societies and the International Federation shall ensure that their personnel, volunteers and partners are aware of the content of these Principles and Rules and are **equipped with the necessary skills and training to comply with them.**
- 8.4 The need for **potential review or amendment** of these Principles and Rules shall be formally considered every four years.
- 8.5 Any **dispute between National Societies, or between National Societies and the International Federation,** related to these Principles and Rules that cannot be resolved by the parties shall be **addressed to the International Federation's compliance and mediation committee,** unless otherwise agreed by the disputing parties.

(IFRC, 2021, p. 20)

D Humanitarian Accountability Partnership (HAP)

D.1 The HAP Standard Principles

The first four Principles are derived from the [Fundamental Principles of the Red Cross](#). The next six are specifically relevant to accountability, with some derived from the HAP Principles of Accountability.

- Humanity: concern for human welfare and respect for the individual.
- Impartiality: providing humanitarian assistance in proportion to need, and giving priority to the most urgent needs, without discrimination (including that based upon gender, age, race, disability, ethnic background, nationality or political, religious, cultural or organisational affiliation).
- Neutrality: aiming only to meet human needs and refraining from taking sides in hostilities or giving material or political support to parties to an armed conflict.
- Independence: acting only under the authority of the organisation's governing body and in line with the organisation's purpose.
- **Participation and informed consent: listening and responding to feedback from crisis-affected people when planning, implementing, monitoring and evaluating programmes**, and making sure that crisis-affected people understand and agree with the proposed humanitarian action and are aware of its implications.
- Duty of care: meeting recognised minimum standards for the well-being of crisis-affected people, and paying proper attention to their safety and the safety of staff.
- **Witness: reporting when the actions of others have a negative effect on the well-being of people in need of humanitarian assistance or protection.**
- Offer redress: enabling crisis-affected people and staff to raise complaints, and responding with appropriate action.
- **Transparency: being honest and open in communications and sharing relevant information, in an appropriate form, with crisis-affected people and other stakeholders.**
- **Complementarity: working as a responsible member of the aid community, co-ordinating with others to promote accountability to, and coherence for, crisis-affected people**

(HAP International, 2010, p. 8)

D.2 Principles of Accountability

1. Commitment to humanitarian standards and rights
 - Members state their commitment to respect and foster humanitarian standards and the rights of beneficiaries
2. Setting standards and building capacity
 - **Members set a framework of accountability to their stakeholders** (Framework of accountability includes standards, quality standards, principles, policies, guidelines, training and other capacity-building work, etc. The framework must include measurable performance indicators. Standards may be internal to the organisation or they may be collective, e.g. Sphere or People In Aid.)
 - **Members set and periodically review their standards and performance indicators, and revise them if necessary**
 - **Members provide appropriate training in the use and implementation of standards**
3. Communication
 - **Members inform, and consult with, stakeholders, particularly beneficiaries and staff, about the standards adopted, programmes to be undertaken and mechanisms available for addressing concerns**
4. Participation in programmes
 - **Members involve beneficiaries in the planning, implementation, monitoring and evaluation of programmes and report to them on progress, subject only to serious operational constraints**
5. Monitoring and reporting on compliance
 - **Members involve beneficiaries and staff when they monitor and revise standards**
 - **Members regularly monitor and evaluate compliance with standards, using robust processes**
 - **Members report at least annually to stakeholders, including beneficiaries, on compliance with standards. Reporting may take a variety of forms**
6. Addressing complaints

- Members enable beneficiaries and staff to report complaints and seek redress safely

7. Implementing Partners

- Members are committed to the implementation of these principles if and when working through implementation partners

(HAP International, 2010, p. 25)

1. Establishing and delivering on commitments

The organisation sets out the commitments that it will be held accountable for, and how they will be delivered.

Requirements		Means of verification	
1.1	The organisation shall produce a written accountability framework that: 1. identifies its stakeholders, with the people it aims to assist as priority; 2. states its commitments, with reference to the people it aims to assist; 3. includes the HAP Standard benchmarks; 4. has been approved by its leadership; and 5. has milestones for each commitment.	1	The accountability framework
1.2	The organisation shall implement its accountability framework through a management system that: 1. makes clear the management roles and responsibilities, including for the governing board; 2. is based on a set of processes that ensures resources are used properly to achieve objectives; 3. involves staff in decision-making; and 4. enables continuous improvement.	1	Records of each point in the requirement relating to commitments in the accountability framework
		2	A strategy or plan for putting the accountability framework into practice
		3	Interviews with staff at different levels

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Figure 5: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning establishing and delivering on commitments (HAP International, 2010, p. 11)

Additional requirements for organisations working with partners

Requirements		Means of verification	
1.3	The organisation's accountability framework shall reflect a commitment to working in partnerships based on mutual accountability, respect, and continual improvement.	1	The accountability framework
1.4	The organisation shall document: 1. its overall approach to working in partnership; 2. the process and criteria for selecting partners and the role of accountability in assessing potential partners; and 3. what is negotiable and non-negotiable when working with partners, referring specifically to the accountability framework.	1	Documents on the organisation's approach to working with partners
		2	Documents, such as staff guidance, on selecting partners
1.5	The organisation shall work with each of its partners to agree on: 1. expectations and working arrangements; 2. the commitments of partners to the people they aim to assist and how these commitments will be met; and 3. if and how the organisation will interact with the people it aims to assist.	1	Interviews with staff of both the organisation and its partners, and records, such as minutes from meetings, of a joint decision-making process
		2	Partner agreements, or other relevant documents that guide partnership arrangements
1.6	The organisation shall work with its partners to improve how partners put relevant parts of the accountability framework into practice.	1	Interviews with staff about, and records (such as workplans and reports) of, activities to improve partners' practice
		2	Examples of improvements

Figure 6: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning establishing and delivering on commitments continued (HAP International, 2010, p.12)

2. Staff competency

The organisation ensures that staff have competencies that enable them to meet the organisation's commitments.

Requirements		Means of verification	
2.1	The organisation shall clearly define and document the knowledge, skills, behaviours and attitudes that staff need to meet its commitments.	1	Job descriptions, recruitment procedures and files, vacancy notices and staff codes of conduct
		2	Interviews with staff responsible for recruitment, appointment, staff development and performance review
2.2	The organisation shall have in place a staff code of conduct which refers to: 1. not exploiting and abusing people, including sexual exploitation and abuse; 2. being sensitive to the local culture; and 3. the responsibility of staff to report abuses.	1	Staff code of conduct and related policies
2.3	The organisation shall ensure that staff understand the code of conduct and their responsibility under the accountability framework.	1	Staff induction and briefing procedures
		2	Samples of contracts and copies of the signed code of conduct
		3	Interviews with staff
2.4	The organisation shall regularly and consistently review and act on staff performance relating to knowledge, skills, behaviours and attitudes needed to meet commitments.	1	A documented process for, and records of, reviewing staff performance
		2	Interviews with staff
		3	Examples of consistent actions following from reviews, including when staff fail to meet the code of conduct
2.5	The organisation shall continually develop its staff so that commitments are met more effectively.	1	Examples and records of staff development activities, including training reports
		2	Interviews with staff on the effect of staff development activities

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Figure 7: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning staff competency (HAP International, 2010, p. 13)

Additional requirements for organisations working with partners

Requirements		Means of verification	
2.6	The organisation shall ensure that staff who interact with its partners understand the partnership agreements, the implications of the organisation's accountability framework for partners, and each partner's obligations.	1	Records of, and interviews about, a process for relevant staff to understand the partnership agreements and their implications
		2	Interviews with staff of both the organisation and partners about the purpose, content and relevance of partnership agreements
2.7	The organisation shall work with its partners to agree on the knowledge, skills, behaviours and attitudes that a partner's staff need to meet agreed commitments, and to ensure these are reflected in a staff code of conduct (as in requirement 2.2).	1	Interviews with staff of both the organisation and its partners, and records, such as minutes from meetings, of a joint decision-making process
		2	Partners' staff codes of conduct
2.8	The organisation shall work with its partners to improve how partners implement and monitor their staff codes of conduct.	1	Interviews with staff about, and records (such as workplans and reports) of, activities to improve partners' practice
		2	Examples of improvements

Figure 8: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning staff competency continued
(HAP International, 2010, p. 14)

3. Sharing information

The organisation ensures that the people it aims to assist and other stakeholders have access to timely, relevant and clear information about the organisation and its activities.

Requirements		Means of verification	
3.1	The organisation shall define and document processes for sharing information, covering: 1. commitment to accurate and timely information sharing; 2. what information it will share with the people it seeks to assist and other stakeholders; 3. how decisions will be made on when and how to share information; and 4. criteria used for deciding not to share information.	1	Documents on processes for sharing information, such as a corporate statement and staff guidelines
3.2	The organisation shall share with the people it aims to assist and other stakeholders information appropriate to their needs, including: 1. its background and contact details; 2. its accountability framework, staff code of conduct and complaints procedure; 3. its goals and project objectives, expected results with the time frame, and a financial summary, as well as summaries of evaluations and progress reports; 4. staff roles and responsibilities; 5. criteria for selecting target groups and deliverables as agreed in requirement 4.2; and 6. how input from participation activities has contributed to decisions.	1	Records of, and interviews with staff and crisis-affected women, men, boys and girls about, a process for developing a context-specific information plan
		2	Observation and interviews with staff and with crisis-affected women, men, boys and girls to confirm that information is shared
		3	Examples of media and records of information sharing activities

Figure 9: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning sharing information (HAP International, 2010, p. 15)

Requirements		Means of verification	
3.3	The organisation shall ensure that information specified in requirement 3.2 is presented in languages, formats and media that are appropriate for, accessible to, and can be understood by the people it aims to assist and other stakeholders.	1	Observation, records, and interviews to confirm a process for deciding appropriate and accessible languages, formats and media
		2	Interviews with people the organisation aims to assist and other stakeholders
3.4	The organisation shall ensure that its staff identify themselves to people they aim to assist and other stakeholders.	1	Observation, records, and interviews to confirm how staff identify themselves, including through identity cards with validity dates, organisation name and contact details
		2	Interviews with people the organisation aims to assist and other stakeholders

Figure 10: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning sharing information continued
(HAP International, 2010, p. 16)

Requirements		Means of verification	
3.5	In agreement with its partners, the organisation shall make public the names of its partners, the main joint activities, and a financial summary of the programmes it funds.	1	Interviews with staff of both the organisation and its partners, and records, such as minutes from meetings, of a joint decision-making process
		2	Examples and records of information sharing activities
3.6	The organisation shall work with its partners to agree on how and when they will share information, including with the people they aim to assist, and to put this agreement into practice.	1	A plan on what information partners will share
		2	Examples and records of information sharing activities, and interviews with affected women, men, boys and girls and with partner staff
3.7	The organisation shall work with its partners to improve how partners meet requirements 3.1 to 3.4.	1	Interviews with staff about, and records (such as workplans and reports) of, activities to improve partners' practice
		2	Examples of improvements

Figure 11: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning sharing information continued
(HAP International, 2010, p. 17)

4. Participation

The organisation listens to the people it aims to assist, incorporating their views and analysis in programme decisions.

Requirements		Means of verification	
4.1	The organisation shall define and document the processes through which it will: 1. identify the people it aims to assist and their representatives, referring to gender, age, diversity and special needs; and 2. enable women, men, boys and girls that it aims to assist, and other stakeholders, to participate in different stages of the project.	1	Documents on participation processes, such as a corporate statement and staff guidelines
4.2	The organisation shall develop and put in place processes appropriate to the context so that the people it aims to assist and other crisis-affected people provide feedback and influence: 1. initial assessment; 2. project design, deliverables, criteria for selecting target groups and the selection process; 3. project implementation; and 4. monitoring and evaluation	1	Records of, and interviews with staff and with crisis-affected women, men, boys and girls about, a process for developing a context-appropriate participation plan
		2	Observation and interviews with staff and with crisis-affected women, men, boys and girls to confirm that participation takes place
		3	Examples and records of participation activities
4.3	The organisation shall enable the people it aims to assist to provide feedback and influence or make decisions about the project in a way that is continuously adapted to the context and the intervention. As a minimum, informed consent shall be obtained for the action.	1	Observation, records, and interviews to confirm a process through which the organisation assesses the capacity to participate and decides what is appropriate
		2	Records of informed consent and other participatory activities
		3	Examples and records that input is affecting decisions

Figure 12: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning participation (HAP International, 2010, p. 18)

Requirements		Means of verification	
4.4	The organisation shall work with its partners to agree on how the people they aim to assist will participate in different stages of the project, and to put this agreement into practice.	1	Interviews with staff of both the organisation and its partners, and records, such as minutes from meetings, of a joint decision-making process
		2	Documents, such as a plan, on how the people they aim to assist will participate
		3	Interviews with staff and with people the organisation aims to assist to confirm that participation takes place as agreed
4.5	The organisation shall work with its partners to improve how partners meet requirements 4.1 to 4.3.	1	Interviews with staff about, and records (such as workplans and reports) of, activities to improve partners' practice
		2	Examples of improvements

Figure 13: HAP Standard benchmarks concerning participation continued (HAP International, 2010, p. 19)